REVELATION

twenty-two chapters · Book lxvi of lxvi

NT | DOMINION

START HERE

Ch. 2–3 · 5 · 13 · 18 · 21

MARGINALIA

WHERE WE ARE

On a prison island, writing to seven congregations under pressure from an empire that calls its emperor divine. This is banned literature, written in code, by a man who has been removed for what he said.

WHAT HAPPENS

Seven letters assessing seven churches, several of them harshly. Then visions: a slaughtered lamb on the throne, seals and trumpets and bowls, a beast whose authority comes from a dragon, a mark required for buying and selling, and a gorgeously dressed city called a whore whose fall is mourned by merchants because their trade is ruined. It ends with the city replaced by a new one where the gates never close.

WHO MATTERS

John of Patmos · the lamb · the beast · the woman clothed with the sun · the merchants, who are the ones who weep

WHAT THIS BOOK WRESTLES WITH

Whether empires end. Its answer is that they do, that their economy is the tell, and that the throne belongs to something that was killed rather than something that kills.

"Come out of her, my people." REV 18.4

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

Your entire visual and rhetorical vocabulary: marks, seals, thrones, beasts, a bride, a whore, gates that never close. And the political core — an empire's fall told through the grief of its merchants.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

Relocate the whole thing to the distant future and appoint itself the interpreter. If the beast is always still coming, it can never be the government currently in the room.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

write here

✣ *See also:* Revelation master section, p. 321; Symbols & Numbers, p. 141.

F1

FOCUSED STUDY SPREAD

NUMBERS

Census, camp, and the two petitions

SOURCE MARGIN

NUM 1–36

MT · LXX

MILGROM, NUMBERS (JPS)

LEVINE, NUMBERS (AB)

UNFINISHED · ART PENDING

PLATE RESERVED

Numbers plate not yet supplied — a camp diagram, a wilderness horizon, or a register page. Drop art here.

FOCUSED STUDY F1 · ◈

NUMBERS

A book that opens by counting everyone and closes by deciding who inherits. Between those two acts it records every complaint the wilderness produced — and treats some of them as rebellion and others as law.

WHY THIS IS FOCUSED, NOT A DOSSIER

Numbers gives Dominion its census, its camp order, and its distinction between approved and criminal petition. That is three things, not a book's worth. Eight pages covers them without pretending you need seventeen.

PROMOTION-ELIGIBLE

If the Trials draw more heavily on census and registration than expected, this spread is promoted to a dossier. The review box is on N08.

WHAT IT IS

NAME	English *Numbers*, from Greek *Arithmoi* and Latin *Numeri* — named for its two censuses. Hebrew *Bemidbar*, "in the wilderness," from the book's opening words. The two naming traditions emphasize different books. **[C]**
PLACE	Fourth book of the Torah. It carries the narrative from Sinai to the edge of the land and holds the material Leviticus does not narrate. **[C]**
STRUCTURE	Three movements by location. Chapters 1–10 at Sinai: counting, camp, and departure. Chapters 11–21 in the wilderness: complaint, scouts, condemnation, rebellion, death. Chapters 22–36 on the plains of Moab: Balaam, the second census, and the inheritance rulings. **[C]**
GENRES INSIDE	Census register, itinerary, legal ruling, narrative, poetry, oracle, and a folk tale about a talking donkey. The registers and the stories were not written to be read the same way. **[C]**
THE FIGURES	The censuses give 603,550 fighting men in chapter 1 and 601,730 in chapter 26 — implying a total population in the millions. Whether those numbers are literal is widely debated; proposals include a different sense of the Hebrew term rendered "thousand," symbolic or schematic totals, and later scribal expansion. No proposal is settled. **[R]**
NEIGHBORS	Ancient Near Eastern military rosters, land grants, and boundary records cover the same administrative ground. Reading Numbers next to them makes it visible as a governing document and not only a story. **[R]**

WHAT THE BOOK IS ACTUALLY ABOUT, IF IT IS ABOUT ONE THING

Who is on the list, and what being on the list gets you. Nearly the entire generation counted in chapter 1 is dead by chapter 26 — Caleb and Joshua are the stated exceptions — and most of the generation that inherits was not counted the first time. **[P]**

WHAT I ALREADY THINK THIS BOOK IS, BEFORE READING IT AGAIN

NUM 1.1

NUM 1–10

NUM 11–21

NUM 22–36

MILGROM, NUMBERS

MENDENHALL, "CENSUS LISTS OF NUM 1 & 26"

TKC: DOM

NUM 1

NUM 2

NUM 3–4

NUM 26

LEVINE, NUMBERS

TKC: DOM · CT

COUNTING AS GOVERNANCE

The census is not neutral. It counts men twenty years old and up who can go to war, by ancestral house. What the text says it produces is a military muster, an ancestral register, and a marching order. Women and children are not counted; the Levites are registered separately, by a different rule and from a different age. **[C]** That a register of this kind also underwrote taxation, corvee labor, and conscription quotas is an inference from ancient Near Eastern administrative practice — reasonable, and not something Numbers states. **[R]**

	FIRST CENSUS · CH. 1	SECOND CENSUS · CH. 26
WHERE	Wilderness of Sinai, second year out.	Plains of Moab, a generation later.
PURPOSE	Muster for war and order the camp.	Allocate land by size of tribe.
TOTAL	603,550	601,730 — almost identical, after forty years of death
WHO SURVIVES	The generation that left Egypt.	Of that generation, Caleb and Joshua only. The list has been almost entirely replaced.
WHAT IT PROVES	That the people are numerous, organized, and ready.	That the promise survived the people who received it. **[P]**

THE CAMP · CH. 2

Twelve tribes in fixed positions on four sides, three to a side, each under its own standard, with the Levites in an inner ring around the tabernacle and Moses and Aaron at the entrance. Position in the camp is not a suggestion. It is assigned, recorded, and reproduced at every stop. **[C]**

WHAT DOMINION TAKES

The whole apparatus, with the theology intact: a register that decides existence, a place assigned by house, and the claim that the arrangement is holy rather than administrative. Household registration is Numbers 2 with a Dominion letterhead. **[P]**

WHO IS COUNTED IN DOMINION, WHO IS ONLY REGISTERED, AND WHO IS NEITHER

TWO SPEAK. ONE IS MARKED.

Numbers 12 is routinely summarized as Miriam challenging Moses. The Hebrew is more precise than either that summary or its correction: verse 1 uses a feminine singular verb for the act of speaking while naming Miriam and Aaron together, and verse 2 shifts to plural speech. Aaron is explicitly present in both verses. The punishment falls on one of them. **[C]**

WHO SPEAKS	Miriam and Aaron, both named, against Moses. Verse 1 carries a feminine singular verb; verse 2 is plural. The grammar foregrounds Miriam without removing Aaron. **[C]**
STATED OCCASION	The Cushite woman Moses had married. The text raises her and then does not return to her. **[C]**
ACTUAL CLAIM	Their question is about prophetic authority — whether the LORD has spoken only through Moses. The marriage is the occasion; the claim is jurisdictional. **[C]**
THE REPLY	A divine speech distinguishing how God speaks to prophets generally from how God speaks to Moses. It answers the question by ranking the office, not by denying that others prophesy. **[C]**
THE PUNISHMENT	Miriam's skin is struck with a scaling disease, described as turning white. Aaron receives no visible punishment. He pleads for her; Moses intercedes; she is put outside the camp seven days. **[C]**
THE DETAIL NOBODY QUOTES	The people do not move until she is brought back in. The camp's entire march waits on the woman it just expelled. **[C]**

WHAT THE TEXT DOES NOT SAY

It does not explain why only Miriam is marked. It offers no reason, no ranking of their guilt, and no comment on the asymmetry. Interpreters have supplied explanations for centuries. Some are grammatical — the feminine singular verb in verse 1 has long been read as putting Miriam first in the act. Some are institutional — that a scale-diseased high priest would have shut down the sanctuary. Some are simply the obvious one. The grammar is real; what it is supposed to justify is not stated. The silence is the text. **[P]**

WHERE I HAVE SEEN THIS ASYMMETRY — IN THE TEXT, IN CHURCHES, IN DOMINION, IN MY OWN CHAPTERS

NUM 12.1

NUM 12.2–8

NUM 12.9–16

EXOD 15 (MIRIAM THE PROPHET)

TRIBLE, "BRINGING MIRIAM OUT"

TKC: MIRIAM

NUM 16

NUM 17

NUM 27 .1–11

NUM 36

JOSH 17.3–6

TKC: CT · DOM

KORAH AND THE DAUGHTERS

These are not the same act with different results. They differ in who brings them, what is asked, how it is asked, where it is asked, and how the narrator frames it. Set them side by side and the question that emerges is not whether Numbers approves of dissent — it is which petitions this authority is able to hear. **[C]**

	KORAH · CH. 16	ZELOPHEHAD'S DAUGHTERS · CH. 27
WHO	Korah, a Levite, with Dathan, Abiram, and On of Reuben, and 250 men of standing.	Mahlah, Noah, Hoglah, Milcah, and Tirzah — five sisters, named individually.
ASKS FOR	Priestly access — the holiness of the whole congregation against Aaron's exclusive office.	An inheritance in their father's name, since he died without sons.
METHOD	Assembly against Moses and Aaron, then a censer contest — a direct test of authority.	They stand before Moses, Eleazar, the chiefs, and the whole congregation at the tent of meeting and state their case.
FRAMING	The narrator calls it rebellion before the reader can weigh it.	The narrator reports the petition without a verdict and lets the ruling answer it.
MOSES	Falls on his face, then proposes the test.	Brings the case before the LORD rather than deciding it himself.
OUTCOME	The ground opens; fire consumes the 250. Chapter 17 then re-secures Aaron's office with a budding staff.	The petition is granted and becomes statute — a general law of inheritance, not a personal favor.
AFTERWARD	Korah's name survives in the Psalms superscriptions — the sons of Korah are singers. **[C]**	Chapter 36 narrows the win: they must marry within their father's tribe so the land does not transfer. The right is granted, then fenced. **[C]**

THE QUESTION TO CARRY, NOT THE CONCLUSION TO PRINT

Which petitions does an authority legitimize, and which does it criminalize? On this evidence: a petition that works inside the system's own procedure, asks for a defined thing, and does not contest who holds the office can be granted and even written into law. A petition that contests the office is answered with the ground. **[P]**

WHICH PETITION IS EDEN BRINGING — AND DOES SHE KNOW WHICH ONE IT LOOKS LIKE?

BUILD THE PROCEDURE

WRITING

NUM 27

NUM 36

TKC: CT · DOM

Dominion has an approved petition and a criminal one. Numbers gives you the template for both. Draft the Empire's version here — this page is source material for the Trials, not a study exercise.

1 · WHAT A LAWFUL PETITION LOOKS LIKE IN DOMINION — WHO MAY BRING IT, WHERE, IN WHOSE PRESENCE

2 · THE LINE A PETITION CROSSES TO BECOME SEDITION — AND WHO DECIDES IT HAS BEEN CROSSED

3 · THE CHAPTER 36 MOVE — A CONCESSION THAT IS LATER FENCED. WHERE DOES DOMINION DO THIS?

4 · A SCENE WHERE A WOMAN WINS SOMETHING REAL AND THE WIN IS IMMEDIATELY NARROWED

NUM 11

NUM 13–14

NUM 20

NUM 21.4–9

2 KGS 18.4

NUM 22–24

NUM 27.12–23

FORTY YEARS OF CONSEQUENCE

THE SCOUTS AND THE CONDEMNED GENERATION · 13–14

Twelve are sent to see the land. All twelve agree it is fertile; ten judge the inhabitants unbeatable, and Caleb and Joshua dissent. The people side with the majority, and the generation is told it will not enter — forty years, a year for each day of scouting. Chapter 14 names the unfavorable report itself as part of the offense, and distinguishes the punishments: the ten who brought it die, and the generation that accepted it is denied entry. **[C]** Whether a line can be drawn between describing an obstacle honestly and presenting it as grounds for communal refusal is a reading the text invites and does not settle. **[P]**

COMPLAINT AS A GENRE · 11, 20, 21

Food, water, leadership, direction, and the memory of Egypt as better than freedom. The complaints are repetitive by design; the book is documenting a pattern, not a bad week. Moses himself complains, at length, and is not punished for it — which is worth holding next to N04. **[C]**

THE BRONZE SERPENT · 21:4–9

Serpents are sent; Moses is instructed to make a bronze one; those who look at it live. Centuries later, 2 Kings 18:4 records Hezekiah destroying it, because people had begun making offerings to it. A divinely commanded object becomes an object that must be destroyed. That arc is directly useful to Dominion's relic theology. **[C]**

BALAAM AND THE DONKEY · 22–24

A foreign diviner is hired by Balak of Moab to curse Israel. His donkey sees the divine messenger before he does and speaks. He then delivers blessings instead of curses, four times. He is a non-Israelite who cannot say anything but what God gives him. Later texts — inside Numbers itself and in the New Testament — treat Balaam as a villain; the Balaam of chapters 22–24 and the Balaam of later reference behave very differently, and the shift is a study in its own right. **[R]**

LEADERSHIP TRANSITION · 27:12–23

Joshua is commissioned publicly, by laying on of hands, before Eleazar and the congregation, while Moses is still alive and will not enter the land. Succession here is a witnessed ceremony, not an inheritance. **[C]**

WHAT DOMINION HARVESTS FROM THE MIDDLE

A theology of delay. If the wilderness is a punishment for the previous generation's failure of nerve, then any present hardship can be explained as inherited discipline, and endurance becomes the whole of obedience. The Trials' Endurance phase is this doctrine with a broadcast schedule. **[P]**

WHICH OF THESE FIVE I ACTUALLY NEED, AND FOR WHICH CHAPTER

WHAT I TAKE OUT OF NUMBERS

WRITING

SPREAD
CLOSE

QUEUE:
F1

THE ONE THING THIS BOOK CHANGED ABOUT HOW I SEE DOMINION

WHAT I STILL DO NOT UNDERSTAND — CARRY TO THE RESEARCH LIST

A LINE, AN IMAGE, OR A PROCEDURE I AM TAKING STRAIGHT INTO THE MANUSCRIPT

PROMOTION REVIEW

log only — no promotion is made here

Numbers is assigned Focused tier with promotion to a full dossier available. Promote if two or more of these are true: the census material becomes structural to the Trials rather than background · Miriam's punishment becomes a load-bearing precedent in the Empire's treatment of women who speak · the petition contrast drives an actual plot decision · the writing pages here filled up and ran out of room.

DECISION | DATE | PAGES NEEDED

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

OPEN
NOTES

F4

FOCUSED STUDY SPREAD

1 & 2 CHRONICLES

Retelling the same history for a different congregation

SOURCE MARGIN

1–2 CHR

MT · LXX

JAPHET, I & II CHRONICLES

KNOPPERS, 1 CHRON (AB)

PLATE RESERVED

Chronicles plate not yet supplied — a genealogical roll, a choir gallery, a scribe's desk. Drop art here.

UNFINISHED · ART PENDING

FOCUSED STUDY F4 · ◈

1 & 2 CHRONICLES

The same centuries, told again, by someone with a temple to justify and a congregation to hold together. What it leaves out is famous. What it adds is more interesting.

WHY FOCUSED

Chronicles is not a new story; it is a second telling. Six pages is enough to hold what changed, why a postexilic community would want it changed, and what an empire learns from a sanctioned retelling.

READ IT AGAINST SAMUEL–KINGS

This spread only works in comparison. Keep a Samuel–Kings text open beside it, or the differences are invisible.

WHAT IT IS

NAME	Hebrew *Divrei Hayyamim*, "the events of the days" — an annals title. The Greek tradition called it *Paraleipomena*, "the things left out," which is a judgment about the book disguised as a label, and one worth noticing. **[C]**
WHERE IT SITS	In the Jewish ordering it is the *last* book of the whole Bible, and it ends with a Persian king telling the exiles to go up. In the Christian ordering it sits after Kings, in the middle. Same text, two different final words. **[C]**
WHEN AND BY WHOM	Anonymous, and generally placed in the Persian period, after the return. Whether the same hand produced Ezra–Nehemiah was long assumed and is now widely questioned. Treat "the Chronicler" as a convenient label for an unknown writer, not an identified person. **[R]**
STRUCTURE	Nine chapters of genealogy. Then David, at length. Then Solomon and the temple. Then the kings of Judah only, down to the exile, closing with the decree of Cyrus. The northern kingdom is largely not its subject. **[C]**
ITS SOURCES	It draws on Samuel and Kings, often nearly word for word, and also cites records the reader cannot check. It is a book openly built out of other books — which makes it the Bible's clearest case study in how a tradition edits itself. **[C]**
ITS PURPOSE	Theological, liturgical, and genealogical, addressed to a community after the exile that needed to know it was continuous with what came before. Framings like "the authorized version" or "state-sponsored scripture" are interpretations of that purpose, not descriptions of it. Use them as arguments you are making, never as facts you are reporting. **[P]**

WHAT THE BOOK IS ACTUALLY DOING

Proving that a small, occupied province with a rebuilt temple is the same people as the kingdom in the old stories. Continuity is the argument; the genealogies are the evidence; the temple is the proof. **[P]**

WHAT I ASSUMED CHRONICLES WAS, BEFORE READING IT NEXT TO KINGS

1 CHR 1–9

2 CHR 36.22–23

JAPHET, I & II CHRON

WILLIAMSON, ISRAEL IN CHRON

1–2 KGS (COMPARE)

TKC: DOM

2 SAM 11–12

1 CHR 3.5

2 SAM 24 · 1 CHR 21

2 CHR 29–31

2 CHR 33.10–20

KNOPPERS, 1 CHRON

SUBTRACTION AND ADDITION

The omissions are the famous part and the least interesting way to read the book. Chronicles also *adds* substantial material that Samuel–Kings does not have, and keeps damaging material it could easily have dropped. Study the pattern, not the gaps alone. **[C]**

MATERIAL	WHAT CHRONICLES DOES WITH IT
Bathsheba and Uriah	The narrative is not retold. Bathsheba herself is *not* erased: she appears in David's genealogy as the mother of Solomon and three other sons, under a variant of her name. Distinguish carefully — the dynastic record keeps her; the scandal narrative is absent. Saying "Bathsheba is gone" is inaccurate. **[C]**
Amnon, Tamar, Absalom	The household violence and the revolt are not retold. The reign is presented through war, worship, and preparation for the temple instead. **[C]**
David's census	*Kept* — including the plague and the deaths. But where Samuel says the LORD incited David, Chronicles says an adversary did. The sin stays; the attribution moves. **[C]** That a book engaged in pure whitewashing would not have kept this chapter is a proposed reading of the retention, not a fact about it. **[P]**
Levites, singers, musicians	*Added*, extensively. Named guilds, rotas, instruments, and duties that Samuel–Kings barely mentions. If you want to know what a working sanctuary staff looked like, this is the source. **[C]**
Hezekiah's Passover	*Added* — a mass reform and festival, with invitations sent north to people outside Judah's jurisdiction. A reunification liturgy. **[C]**
Manasseh	*Added* — Kings gives Judah's worst king no redemption; Chronicles has him taken to Babylon in hooks, pray, and be restored. The most theologically loaded addition in the book: no reign is beyond repentance. **[C]**

HOW TO READ THE OMISSIONS HONESTLY

A retelling that assumes its reader already knows the older account is not the same thing as a retelling that hides it — and Chronicles cites the older account. "Cover-up" is one available reading. So is: a liturgical history written for worship rather than a court chronicle written for judgment. Hold both, and say which one you are using. **[P]**

WHICH OMISSION I FIND HARDEST TO READ CHARITABLY, AND WHY

THE REGISTER AS AN ARGUMENT

1 CHR 1–2

1 CHR 2.34–35

1 CHR 4.9–10

1 CHR 7.24

1 CHR 9.1–34

KNOPPERS, 1 CHRON

TKC: DOM

Nine chapters most readers skip are the book's foundation. A community whose records were disrupted by deportation is establishing, name by name, who belongs, who serves, and who holds land. This is the same instrument as Numbers 1, used for a different purpose: not to muster an army but to prove a people did not end. **[P]**

FROM ADAM FORWARD

The list begins with the first human and narrows: the nations, then Israel, then the tribes, then Judah, then David, then the priests and Levites, then the settlers of Jerusalem. A funnel. The whole world is in the frame at verse one so that the small province at the end can be its point. **[C]**

THE WOMEN IN THE LISTS

Named women are recorded here more often than these chapters' reputation suggests. Sheerah builds Lower and Upper Beth-horon and Uzzen-sheerah (1 Chr 7:24). Sheshan has no sons and gives his daughter to Jarha, his Egyptian servant, and the line is traced through them (2:34–35) — the text records the marriage and the descent; it does not state that she inherits. Hammolecheth is named as a sister among Manasseh's descendants (7:18). Bithiah, a daughter of Pharaoh, is recorded as a wife without comment (4:18). Jabez's mother is the one who names him (4:9). Nobody preaches these chapters, so nobody notices. Mine them. **[C]**

WHAT A GENEALOGY DOES POLITICALLY

It assigns priestly eligibility, land claims, and standing. It also excludes: to be absent from the register is to have no documented claim. The list is simultaneously a comfort and a boundary. **[P]**

GAPS, VARIANTS, AND WHY THEY DO NOT MATTER HERE

Names, spellings, and lines differ from parallels elsewhere in the Bible, and some segments are incomplete. Ancient genealogies were not birth certificates; they were claims about relationship, arranged to make a point. Judging them by modern record-keeping standards misses what they were for. **[R]**

THE DIRECT LINE TO DOMINION

Household registration, lineage verification, and the Covenant record are this technology. An Empire that decides standing by registered household has read Chronicles correctly — and has quietly reversed it, because Chronicles keeps the register to include a scattered people, and Dominion keeps it to rank a gathered one. **[P]**

WHO IN MY CAST IS NOT ON A REGISTER, AND WHAT THAT COSTS THEM

WRITING

2 CHR
36

TKC: DOM
· TL

WRITE THE EMPIRE'S SECOND TELLING

Dominion has an official history of the Fall. Chronicles shows you how a sanctioned retelling actually behaves: it keeps more than you expect, adds liturgy, relocates blame rather than deleting it, and ends on the note it wants remembered. Build yours on that model, not on crude deletion.

1 · WHAT THE EMPIRE'S HISTORY OF THE FALL KEEPS, EVEN THOUGH IT IS DAMAGING

2 · WHERE IT MOVES THE BLAME RATHER THAN REMOVING THE EVENT

3 · THE LITURGY IT ADDS — WHAT THE OFFICIAL VERSION HAS THAT THE OLD ONE DID NOT

4 · THE LAST SENTENCE OF THE OFFICIAL HISTORY — DRAFT IT WORD FOR WORD

WHAT I TAKE OUT OF CHRONICLES

WRITING

SPREAD CLOSE

QUEUE: F4

THE ONE DIFFERENCE FROM SAMUEL–KINGS THAT CHANGED MY READING

A NAME FROM THE GENEALOGIES I WANT TO USE, AND WHERE

WHAT I STILL DO NOT UNDERSTAND — CARRY TO THE RESEARCH LIST

PROMOTION REVIEW

log only — no promotion is made here

Chronicles is assigned Focused tier. Log a promotion candidacy if the Empire's official history becomes a plot object rather than background, or if the register material outgrows this spread. The audit also floats a combined study with Ezra and Nehemiah titled *Restoration, Record, and Exclusion* — that decision is open and is recorded in the backlog, not here.

LOGGED | DATE | REASON

NOTES

OPEN
NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

F5

FOCUSED STUDY SPREAD

EZRA

An imperially funded restoration, and the assembly that sent families away

SOURCE MARGIN

EZRA 1–10

MT · LXX

WILLIAMSON, EZRA, NEHEMIAH

BLENKINSOPP, EZRA–NEH

PLATE RESERVED

Ezra plate not yet supplied — a sealed decree, foundations in rain, a crowd in an open square. Drop art here.

UNFINISHED · ART PENDING

FOCUSED STUDY F5 · ◈

EZRA

A homecoming paid for by the empire that permitted it, and a covenant renewal that ends with women and children being sent out of the community. Both halves are the same book.

WHY FOCUSED

Ten chapters, two movements, one unresolved ending. Seven pages hold the imperial mechanics and the marriage crisis without turning either into a verdict, and give this study the same notes space as the rest of the tier.

CONTENT PREPARATION

X04 deals with the expulsion of wives and children from the community, and with the ethical dispute over what to call it. Marked on the page itself.

WHAT IT IS

ONE BOOK OR TWO	Ezra and Nehemiah were transmitted together in the Hebrew tradition and separated later, and they are commonly studied as a shared literary corpus. Whether they are one composition, and by whose hand, remains disputed. This companion studies them as separate spreads because the audit split them, and treats the shared-corpus reading as a tradition of study rather than a settled compositional fact. **[R]**
STRUCTURE	Chapters 1–6: the first returns and the rebuilding of the temple, decades before Ezra himself appears. Chapters 7–10: Ezra arrives with a royal commission, and the community confronts intermarriage. There is a long gap between the two halves that the book does not narrate. **[C]**
TWO LANGUAGES	Part of the book is in Aramaic, the administrative language of the Persian empire, and that section is largely made of correspondence — petitions, archival searches, and decrees. The book quotes paperwork. Whether the documents are authentic, edited, or composed is debated. **[R]**
WHO PAYS	The empire. Cyrus authorizes the return and the release of temple vessels; Artaxerxes later sends Ezra with silver, gold, provisions, tax exemptions for temple personnel, and authority to appoint judges. The restoration is a Persian-sanctioned project from the first verse. **[C]**
EZRA HIMSELF	A priest by descent and a scribe of the law, arriving from Babylon with a commission. He is a religious authority whose standing is issued by a foreign king. Hold both halves of that at once. **[C]**
HOW IT ENDS	With a list of names of men who had married foreign women, and a final verse whose Hebrew is difficult. There is no resolution scene, no aftermath, and no account of what became of the women and children. The book simply stops. **[C]**

WHAT THE BOOK IS ACTUALLY ABOUT

Survival of a small community under imperial patronage, and the boundary it draws to achieve it. Ezra is a book about what a threatened people is willing to do to remain identifiable. **[P]**

WHAT I EXPECTED A "RETURN FROM EXILE" BOOK TO FEEL LIKE

EZRA 1.1–4

EZRA 4.8–6.18 (ARAMAIC)

EZRA 7.11–26

EZRA 10.44

BLENKINSOPP, EZRA–NEH

TKC: DOM

EZRA 1

EZRA 2

EZRA 3 .10–13

EZRA 4

EZRA 6 .13–18

WILLIAMSON, EZRA, NEH

A TEMPLE BUILT BY PERMISSION

Nothing in the first six chapters happens without imperial authorization, and the book does not treat that as a compromise. Persia is the instrument of the return. For a novelist building an empire that licenses religion, this is the primary text. **[C]**

THE DECREE AND THE VESSELS

Cyrus issues the authorization, and the temple vessels taken by Babylon are counted back out of an imperial treasury. Property that was looted is returned as policy. Restoration arrives as an inventory. **[C]**

THE LIST OF WHO RETURNED

A register by household and town, including a group who could not document their descent and were consequently excluded from priestly service until a ruling could be obtained. The register decides standing on arrival. Note this beside Chronicles and Numbers: the same instrument, a third time, doing a third job. **[C]**

TWO SOUNDS AT THE FOUNDATION

When the foundation is laid, the young shout for joy and the old who remembered the first house weep, and the text says the noise could not be told apart. One of the most useful sentences in the Bible for writing a restoration scene. **[C]**

OPPOSITION AS PAPERWORK

The work is stopped not by an army but by a letter: neighboring officials write to the king describing the rebuilding as a security risk, an archive is searched, and construction halts until a later search finds the original decree and reverses the ruling. Bureaucratic obstruction, on both sides, in writing. **[C]**

WHO IS TURNED AWAY EARLY

People already living in the land offer to help build and are refused. The refusal is stated without justification beyond the decree. The boundary that dominates chapters 9–10 is drawn here first, over labor. **[C]**

WHAT DOMINION FUNDS, AND WHAT IT REQUIRES IN RETURN FOR FUNDING IT

CONTENT PREPARATION

This page concerns the expulsion of women and their children from a community by collective decision, and the ethical dispute over how to describe it. You may work it later, or not at all, and the spread still functions.

THE BOUNDARY, AND WHO PAID FOR IT

WHAT HAPPENS	Officials report that men of the community, including priests and Levites, have married women of the surrounding peoples. Ezra tears his clothes, prays a long confession in the first person plural, and a proposal is made to separate from the wives and the children born to them. An assembly agrees, a commission is appointed to examine cases household by household, and a list of names is recorded. **[C]**
THE CHILDREN	The children are named in the proposal alongside the wives. This is not incidental — it is the point at which a boundary about identity becomes a decision about specific children. **[C]**
THE SILENCES	No woman speaks. None is named. Where they went, who received them, whether they had families to return to, and what happened to the children is not recorded. There is a note of dissent from a few men, and the text does not explain it. **[C]**
WHAT "FOREIGN" MEANS	Genuinely disputed. Some read an ethnic boundary; some a religious one; some a struggle over land and inheritance between returnees and those who never left; some read the list of peoples as archaizing legal language rather than a description of the actual women. The stakes of the reading are high, and the text does not settle it. **[R]**
SCALE	The recorded list is around a hundred men. Whether the action described was carried out fully, partially, or is an idealized account of a policy is debated — and the parallel action later in Nehemiah suggests the matter did not stay settled. **[R]**

ON THE PHRASE THIS COMPANION WILL NOT USE

"Ethnic cleansing with a liturgy" imports a twentieth-century legal category into a text whose scale, mechanism, and definition of the group are all disputed. It also flattens a real and serious ethical problem into a slogan, which makes it easier to dismiss. The ethical dispute is preserved on this page in full; the phrase is not used, and no formulation of the objection is treated as accurate simply because it is forceful. **[P]**

WRITE ONE OF THE WOMEN. NAME HER. GIVE HER THE SENTENCE THE TEXT DID NOT.

EZRA 9

EZRA 10

NEH 13 .23–30

DEUT 7 .1–4

SOUTHWOOD, ETHNICITY & THE MIXED MARRIAGE CRISIS

ESKENAZI, IN AN AGE OF PROSE

WRITING

SPREAD
CLOSE

QUEUE:
F5

WHAT I TAKE OUT OF EZRA

A RELIGIOUS AUTHORITY WHOSE POWER IS ISSUED BY THE EMPIRE — WHO IS THIS IN MY CAST?

A BOUNDARY DRAWN TO PROTECT A COMMUNITY THAT COSTS THE MOST VULNERABLE PEOPLE IN IT

WHAT I STILL DO NOT UNDERSTAND — CARRY TO THE RESEARCH LIST

PROMOTION REVIEW

log only — no promotion is made here

Ezra is assigned Focused tier. Log a promotion candidacy if the marriage crisis becomes a governing precedent in Dominion's law rather than a parallel, or if the imperial-patronage material carries the Sanctum's origin story. The combined *Restoration, Record, and Exclusion* study remains an open question in the backlog.

LOGGED | DATE | REASON

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

NOTES

OPEN NOTES

NOTES

CONTINUED

CONTINUATION — CARRIED ON FROM X06

F6

FOCUSED STUDY SPREAD

NEHEMIAH

A wall, a register, a debt crisis, and a governor who worked for the king

SOURCE MARGIN

NEH 1–13

MT · LXX

WILLIAMSON, EZRA, NEHEMIAH

ESKENAZI, IN AN AGE OF PROSE

PLATE RESERVED

Nehemiah plate not yet supplied — a half-built wall, a night ride, a gate under guard. Drop art here.

UNFINISHED · ART PENDING

FOCUSED STUDY F6 · ◈

NEHEMIAH

A memoir by a man who held a post in the imperial court, went home with an escort, rebuilt the city's defenses in fifty-two days, canceled the debts his own class held, and then enforced a boundary by force.

WHY FOCUSED

Nehemiah is among the most administratively detailed books in the Old Testament, and the one closest to how Dominion actually runs. Six pages holds the mechanics: employment, security, registers, debt, and enforcement.

FIRST PERSON

Much of the book is Nehemiah's own account of himself, including his prayers asking to be remembered for it. Read it as testimony from an interested party, which is what it is.

WHAT IT IS

HIS JOB	Cupbearer to the Persian king — a service office at court, and a trusted one: it carries personal access to the monarch, which is not the same as ordinary domestic service. He then serves as governor of the province. His authority to act in Jerusalem is delegated imperial authority. **[C]**
FORM	Largely a first-person memoir, with lists, letters, a covenant document, and a long public reading inserted. Scholars commonly identify a "Nehemiah memoir" running through the book with other material set into it; where the seams fall is debated. **[R]**
STRUCTURE	Chapters 1–7: the commission, the night inspection, the building, the opposition, the debt crisis, and a register. Chapters 8–10: the public reading of the law, confession, and a signed covenant. Chapters 11–13: settlement lists, dedication, and a final enforcement campaign. **[C]**
THE WALL	Rebuilt in fifty-two days by assigned crews working on the section nearest their own house, with families, guilds, and perfumers named. Also: half the workforce armed while the other half built. Defense and construction as one operation. **[C]**
HOW IT ENDS	Not with dedication but with a return visit and a purge: the temple chamber cleared, Sabbath trade shut down by locking the gates, and confrontations over marriages that include physical violence and cursing. The book closes with Nehemiah asking to be remembered for good. **[C]**

WHAT THE BOOK IS ACTUALLY ABOUT

Building an institution and then policing it. The construction is the first half; the enforcement is the second, and the book does not present them as different projects. **[P]**

WHAT I WAS TAUGHT ABOUT NEHEMIAH, AND WHAT THAT TEACHING LEFT OUT

NEH 1.11

NEH 2 .1–9

NEH 3

NEH 4 .15–23

NEH 13

WILLIAMSON, EZRA, NEH

TKC: DOM

NEH 2 .7–9

NEH 2 .11–16

NEH 3 .12

NEH 4

NEH 6 .1–14

NEH 7 .1–5

SECURITY AS A THEOLOGY

The wall is the book's controlling image and it is not a metaphor: it is a defensive perimeter with gates, guards, hours, and a list of who is allowed to open them. Everything the second half of the book does about identity is already implied in the first half's masonry. **[P]**

THE PAPERWORK HE ASKS FOR

Letters of safe passage to the provincial governors and a requisition to the keeper of the royal forest for timber. Then an escort of officers and cavalry. He does not arrive as a pilgrim; he arrives as an official with a materials order. **[C]**

THE NIGHT INSPECTION

He surveys the ruins at night, telling no one what he intends, then presents the plan as an accomplished decision. Information control precedes construction. **[C]**

WHO BUILDS

Priests, goldsmiths, perfumers, district rulers, people from outlying towns, and one official who builds with his daughters. Chapter 3 is a labor roster, and one of the clearest places in the Bible where you can see a whole community's trades assigned to a public works project. **[C]**

OPPOSITION, RUMOR, AND A SET-UP

Ridicule, threat of attack, repeated invitations to a meeting outside the city, an open letter alleging he intends to make himself king, and a hired prophet advising him to hide in the temple. He refuses all of it. This is the clearest sequence in scripture on how a construction project becomes a political accusation. **[C]**

THE GATES AND THE REGISTER

Once the wall stands, he sets gate-opening hours and appoints guards, and then — immediately, in the same breath — convenes an enrollment by genealogy. Wall and register arrive together. That sequence is worth marking. **[C]**

DOMINION'S PERIMETER — WHERE IT IS, WHO GUARDS IT, WHEN IT OPENS

CHAPTER FIVE

NEH 5 .1–5

NEH 5 .6–13

NEH 5 .14–19

LEV 25 (COMPARE)

DEUT 15 (COMPARE)

TKC: DOM · MEN

In the middle of the building project the account breaks off for a debt crisis: the workers are hungry and their children are being taken. The text does not report that construction stopped — it reports a crisis serious enough to interrupt the narrative and threaten the project. This is the most economically explicit chapter in the historical books, and the least preached. **[C]**

THE OUTCRY	A great outcry from the people, and the text specifies *and their wives* — women are named as raising it. Three groups speak: those with no land, those mortgaging land for grain, and those who have borrowed against fields and vineyards to pay the king's tax. **[C]**
THE CHILDREN	They say their children are being enslaved for debt, and their daughters already have been, and they are powerless because the fields belong to others now. Debt bondage inside the community, in the same weeks as the sacred building project. **[C]**
WHO THE CREDITORS ARE	The nobles and officials — the same class doing the building and signing the covenant. The crisis is internal. No foreign oppressor is required. **[C]**
THE REMEDY	Nehemiah confronts them publicly, calls it wrong, orders restoration of fields, houses, and the interest taken, and makes them swear to it before the priests. He also renounces the governor's food allowance and reports feeding a large table at his own expense. Reform enacted by a member of the creditor class, on the creditor class. **[C]**
THE LIMIT	Chapter 5 records immediate relief — fields, houses, and interest restored, secured by oath and personal authority. The later covenant in chapter 10 is where a seventh-year release is formalized as a standing obligation. Neither is a structural change to the lending system or to the imperial tax that drove the borrowing, and the text does not report how long either reform was enforced. **[P]**

THE TAX IS THE ENGINE

The people say explicitly that they borrowed to pay the king's tax. The debt crisis is downstream of imperial extraction, and the reform touches the local creditor rather than the empire — because the empire is not available to be reformed. For an author writing a Dominion economy, that is the whole shape of it. **[P]**

HOW A DOMINION HOUSEHOLD LOSES A DAUGHTER TO DEBT — WRITE THE MECHANISM

NEH 8

NEH 9

NEH 10 .28–39

NEH 13 .4–14

NEH 13 .15–22

NEH 13 .23–31

FISHBANE, BIBLICAL INTERPRE-TATION

SIGNED, THEN POLICED

The middle of the book is a public reading and a signed agreement. The end of the book is what happens when the agreement is not kept. Read the two together or the ending looks arbitrary. **[C]**

THE PUBLIC READING

A day-long reading in an open square before men and women and all who could understand, with Levites giving the sense so that the people understood. The people weep; they are told to feast instead and to send portions to those who have none. Public reading and expert explanation are what the verse states. **[C]** Whether "giving the sense" also means translation into Aramaic is a common reading of the phrase and a debated one, not an established fact — verify before repeating it. **[R]** Either way, this is one scene in which text, explanation, and public reception happen together.

THE SIGNED COVENANT

A sealed document with named signatories, committing to specific obligations: no intermarriage, no Sabbath trade, a seventh-year remission, a temple tax, wood offerings, and firstfruits. Note what it is — a funding and compliance schedule with a religious preamble. **[C]**

THE TEMPLE CHAMBER

He returns and finds a room in the temple given to an outsider and the Levites unpaid and gone back to their fields. He throws the household goods out and reinstates the payments. The reform failed the moment its enforcer left. **[C]**

THE SABBATH SHUTDOWN

Treading presses, hauling grain, and foreign traders selling on the Sabbath. He orders the gates shut before dark and posts his own men, and when merchants camp outside he threatens to lay hands on them. Sabbath observance enforced as a border operation. **[C]**

THE MARRIAGE CONFRONTATION

He reports contending with the men, cursing them, striking some, and pulling out their hair, and driving out a priest's son-in-law connected by marriage to a rival governor. He reports this approvingly, as evidence of zeal. Unlike Ezra 10 there is no assembly, no commission, and no list — this is personal violence by an official, recorded in the first person. **[C]** The political dimension is visible too: the marriages in question tie Jerusalem's priestly families to neighboring provincial power. **[P]**

A REFORMER WHOSE REFORM ONLY HOLDS WHILE HE IS IN THE ROOM — WHO IS THAT HERE?

WHAT I TAKE OUT OF NEHEMIAH

WRITING

SPREAD CLOSE

QUEUE: F6

THE PERIMETER AND THE REGISTER ARRIVE TOGETHER — WHERE DOES DOMINION DO THIS?

LEADERSHIP AIMED AT ONE'S OWN CLASS — WHO IN MY CAST REFORMS THE PEOPLE THEY BELONG TO?

A SCENE WHERE OBSERVANCE IS ENFORCED BY LOCKING A GATE

WHAT I STILL DO NOT UNDERSTAND — CARRY TO THE RESEARCH LIST

PROMOTION REVIEW

log only — no promotion is made here

Nehemiah is assigned Focused tier. Log a promotion candidacy if the debt-and-bondage material becomes the spine of Dominion's economy rather than one mechanism, or if chapter 5 outgrows the single page it has here. The combined *Restoration, Record, and Exclusion* study remains an open question in the backlog.

LOGGED | DATE | REASON

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

OPEN NOTES

F2

FOCUSED STUDY SPREAD

ECCLESIASTES

Hevel, the court passages, and useful fatalism

SOURCE MARGIN

ECCL 1–12

MT · LXX

FOX, QOHELET

SEOW, ECCL (AB)

UNFINISHED · ART PENDING

PLATE RESERVED

Ecclesiastes plate not yet supplied — vapor, breath on glass, an empty court. Drop art here.

FOCUSED STUDY F2 · ◈

ECCLESIASTES

A book inside the canon that says the system cannot be figured out, the record will not be kept, and you should eat your dinner anyway. Dangerous material for an empire that needs meaning assigned from above.

WHY FOCUSED, NOT A DOSSIER

Twelve short chapters, one sustained argument. What you need is *hevel* handled correctly and the court passages pulled out. Six pages does that.

READ IT WHOLE FIRST

One of the few biblical books short enough to read in an hour, and it does not survive being read in fragments. Do that before working these pages.

WHAT IT IS

ECCL 1.1

ECCL 1.12

ECCL 12.9–14

FOX, QOHELET

JOB (COMPARE)

TKC: DOM

NAME	Hebrew *Qohelet*, from a root meaning to assemble or convene — roughly "the Assembler," one who addresses a gathering. The Greek title translates it. A role, not a personal name. **[C]**
THE SPEAKER	Introduced as "son of David, king in Jerusalem." Solomon is never named. Best understood as a *literary persona* — a royal voice adopted so the experiment of chapters 1–2 can be run with unlimited means. Modern scholarship generally dates the book's Hebrew well after Solomon, commonly Persian or Hellenistic; that is a scholarly conclusion, not settled fact. Do not treat the speaker as a historical king with unlimited resources without saying you are doing it. **[R]**
TWO VOICES	First person for eleven and a half chapters, then a third-person voice at the end describing Qohelet from outside and commending him with qualifications. Many read that epilogue as an editorial frame. Whether it endorses, domesticates, or corrects the book is genuinely disputed. **[R]**
GENRE	Wisdom literature turned adversarial — it uses the forms of instruction to interrogate instruction. Royal testament, observation report, proverb collection, and poem sit side by side. **[C]**
STRUCTURE	No tidy outline, and proposals for one disagree. What is visible: the royal experiment (1–2), the times poem (3), a run of observations on injustice, labor, wealth, and death (4–10), advice for the young and the closing poem on age (11–12), then the epilogue. **[C]**
NEIGHBORS	Egyptian and Mesopotamian pessimism literature and royal testaments cover comparable ground. Job is the closer canonical neighbor: both refuse the standard reward-and-punishment account, by different routes. **[R]**

WHAT THE BOOK IS ACTUALLY ARGUING

That the outcomes do not track the merits, that nobody can see the whole pattern, and that this is a reason to take what is in front of you seriously rather than a reason to stop. The book is not despairing. It is refusing to lie. **[P]**

WHAT I WAS TAUGHT THIS BOOK MEANT, AND WHO TAUGHT ME

ECCL 1.2

ECCL 12.8

BDB · HALOT HEVEL

GEN 4 (ABEL)

VULGATE VANITAS

KJV 1611

HEVEL

One Hebrew word appears dozens of times across twelve chapters and frames the entire book, first and last. Its concrete sense is vapor, breath, or mist — something real that will not stay in your hand. Every English rendering is an interpretation, and each one produces a different book. **[C]**

RENDERING	THE BOOK IT PRODUCES
"Vanity"	The traditional English, reaching us through the Latin *vanitas*. In modern English it now suggests conceit, which is not the sense. It makes the book sound like a sermon against pride.
"Meaningless"	The strongest and the most misleading. It turns an observation about impermanence into a metaphysical verdict — and the book keeps recommending things, which a meaningless world does not permit.
"Absurd"	Emphasizes the mismatch between what should follow and what does. Useful, and anachronistic in its philosophical baggage.
"Futile"	Keeps the effort and denies it a result. Fits the labor passages, fits the enjoyment passages badly.
"Vapor" / "breath"	Keeps the image and lets the reader do the work. It also connects to the name Abel in Genesis 4 — the same consonants — a resonance the Hebrew reader hears and the English reader never does. **[R]**

WHAT THE BOOK ALSO SAYS — DO NOT CUT THIS HALF

Eat, drink, find good in your labor. Enjoy your bread and your work. Do it with the person you love. These recommendations recur through the book, not once at the end, and they are the counterweight to every "vapor" verdict. A summary that keeps only the bleak half is not summarizing this book. **[C]**

QUOTATION WARNING

"Eat your bread, love someone, the day is short" is a *paraphrase* of the enjoyment passages, not a verse. Likewise "nobody will remember you" compresses several passages on memory and drops the ones about a good name and about what is worth doing. Never print either as a quotation. **[C]**

WHICH RENDERING I AM USING, AND WHY THAT ONE

WRITTEN BY SOMEONE WHO HAS BEEN NEAR POWER

ECCL 4.1

ECCL 5.8–9

ECCL 8.2–4

ECCL 10.16–20

SEOW, ECCL

TKC: CT · DOM

The book's political passages are the ones nobody quotes on a coffee mug. They read like advice from a person who has watched administration from the inside and does not expect it to improve. **[C]**

OPPRESSION WITH NO COMFORTER · 4:1

He looks at the oppressed and notes twice, in the same breath, that they have no one to comfort them — and that power sits on the other side. No theodicy is offered. The observation is left standing. **[C]**

THE CHAIN OF OFFICIALS · 5:8–9

Do not be astonished at extraction and denial of justice in the province — and then a clause about one official above another. These verses are among the most textually difficult in the book, and translations diverge sharply on who is watching whom and whether verse 9 defends or indicts the king. A tiered bureaucracy in which each level answers upward is one strong and common reading; it is not the only one the Hebrew allows. **[R]**

OBEY, BECAUSE HE CAN · 8:2–4

Keep the king's command. Do not stand in a bad cause before him. His word is authoritative, and no one asks him what he is doing. This is counsel for survival, not an endorsement — and Dominion will print it as an endorsement. **[P]**

THE BIRDS WILL CARRY IT · 10:20

Do not curse the king even in your thought, or the rich in your bedroom — a bird of the air may carry the word. A surveillance proverb, in the canon, roughly two and a half millennia before the Broadcast. Take this one whole. **[C]**

THE LAND WITH A CHILD FOR A KING · 10:16–17

Woe to the land whose ruler is a child and whose officials feast in the morning. A blessing on the land whose ruler is of noble birth and whose officials eat at the proper time. Class assumption fully intact — the book criticizes governance without questioning who is entitled to govern. Worth naming. **[P]**

WHICH OF THESE COULD BE READ ALOUD IN THE SANCTUM WITHOUT ANYONE FLINCHING — AND WHICH COULD NOT

ECCL 3 .1–8

ECCL 9.11

ECCL 12.13–14

TKC: DOM · CT

WRITING

THE MOST USEFUL BOOK IN THE EMPIRE'S HANDS

Fatalism is an excellent instrument of government. If nothing can be changed, nothing needs changing, and the person who says so sounds wise rather than compliant. Ecclesiastes can be made to say this. It does not say it — but the raw material is all there, and the Sanctum would not have to add a word. **[P]**

THE PASSAGE	THE USE, AND WHAT IT LEAVES OUT
A time for everything · 3:1–8	Read as divine scheduling: your suffering has been allotted a season, so endure it on time. What it leaves out — the poem lists killing, tearing down, and hating as appointed too, which makes it a description of the whole range of human doing, not a comfort.
Time and chance · 9:11	Read as: outcomes are not yours to control, so accept your placement. What it leaves out — the verse is a direct denial that the swift and the strong reliably win, which undercuts every ranked competition the Empire runs.
Obey the king · 8:2–4	Read as a standing command. What it leaves out — the reason given is that he has the power, not that he has the right.
The epilogue · 12:13–14	The Sanctum's favorite verse in the book, because it is the one sentence that sounds like an instruction. Quoting the last two verses and skipping the twelve chapters is the single cleanest example of the Empire's reading method. **[P]**

THE HARDER QUESTION FOR TKC

Fatalism also protects people. A woman who believes the outcome was never hers to determine can survive a verdict that would otherwise destroy her. The Empire teaches this doctrine cynically and some of your characters will need it sincerely. Do not resolve that tension — write it.

WHO IN MY CAST BELIEVES THIS SINCERELY, AND WHO TEACHES IT KNOWING BETTER

WHAT I TAKE OUT OF ECCLESIASTES

WRITING

ECCL 12.9–14

QUEUE: F2

THE EPILOGUE — DOES IT ENDORSE THE BOOK, TAME IT, OR ARGUE WITH IT? MY READING

A SANCTUM TEACHING BUILT ON THIS BOOK — DRAFT THE ACTUAL WORDING

A CHARACTER WHO HAS ARRIVED AT THIS BOOK'S CONCLUSION HONESTLY

WHAT I STILL DO NOT UNDERSTAND — CARRY TO THE RESEARCH LIST

PROMOTION REVIEW

log only — no promotion is made here

Ecclesiastes is assigned Focused tier. Log a promotion candidacy if the Empire's use of this book becomes a plot thread in its own right rather than atmosphere — if the Sanctum starts *teaching* it on the page, the epilogue will need its own spread.

LOGGED | DATE | REASON

NOTES

OPEN
NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

F3

FOCUSED STUDY SPREAD

EZEKIEL

Exile, the departing glory, and chapters 16 and 23

SOURCE MARGIN

EZEK 1–48

MT · LXX

GREENBERG, EZEKIEL (AB)

PEARCE & WUNSCH, DOCUMENTS OF JUDEAN EXILES

UNFINISHED · ART PENDING

PLATE RESERVED

Ezekiel plate not yet supplied — wheels, a river, an emptied sanctuary, a field of bone. Drop art here.

FOCUSED STUDY F3 · ◈

EZEKIEL

A priest deported before the city fell, writing from a river in Babylonia about a God who left the building. Also the book that uses a woman's violated body as its central image of a nation's guilt — twice, at length.

WHY FOCUSED — FOR NOW

Six pages holds the exile setting, the departing glory, the symbolic performances, and the chapters 16 and 23 problem. If any one of those becomes structural to TKC, this spread is promoted. It is the strongest promotion candidate in the queue.

CONTENT PREPARATION

Z04 handles sexual violence, public exposure as punishment, and the use of a woman's body as a metaphor for national guilt. It is marked on the page itself. Skipping it is a legitimate choice; skipping it unknowingly is not.

WHAT IT IS

EZEK 1.1–3

2 KGS 24–25 · JER 1.1

EZEK 1–24

EZEK 33–48

GREENBERG, EZEKIEL

TKC: TL · DOM

THE MAN	A priest, son of Buzi, among the deportees by the river Chebar in Babylonia. He is not the only prophet of priestly descent — Jeremiah is introduced as being of the priests of Anathoth. What is distinctive about Ezekiel is the combination: a priest whose entire recorded ministry takes place in exile, away from the sanctuary he was trained to serve. That formation shapes everything the book does with temple, purity, and space. **[C]**
THE SETTING	Babylon takes Jerusalem's elite in stages. Ezekiel is deported in an early wave, roughly a decade *before* the city and temple are destroyed. So the first half of the book is written by a man warning an exile community about a catastrophe that has not happened yet — and which most of his hearers believe will not. **[C]**
WHAT DEPORTATION WAS	Imperial policy, not a stampede: selective removal of a ruling class, craftsmen, and royal family, resettlement in colonies, retention of some property and internal community structure, and a puppet administration left behind. It was designed to decapitate a state while keeping it productive. **[R]**
STRUCTURE	Chapters 1–24, judgment on Jerusalem before the fall. 25–32, oracles against surrounding nations. 33–48, after the fall: restoration, the shepherds, the bones, and a measured temple. The fall of the city is the hinge, and the book is deliberately built around it. **[C]**
DATING SYSTEM	The book dates its oracles by elapsed years counted from King Jehoiachin's deportation — not by Babylonian regnal years and not from the fall of the city. **[C]** A community that files its documents from the year its king was taken, rather than from the reign of the power that took him, is making a choice about whose time it lives in. Reading that as deliberate is interpretation. **[P]**

DO NOT REDUCE THIS BOOK TO A MOBILE GOD

The departure of the divine glory from the temple is genuinely central and genuinely useful to Dominion. It is not the whole book. Ezekiel is also a book about individual accountability, failed leadership, the ethics of prophetic speech, and a highly specified plan for rebuilding — and it ends with architecture, not travel. **[C]**

WHAT AN EXILE COMMUNITY KEEPS — AND WHAT DOMINION WOULD TAKE FIRST

EZEK 1

EZEK 2–3

EZEK 4–5

EZEK 8–11

EZEK 12

EZEK 24.15–27

EZEK 43

A PROPHET USED AS AN INSTRUMENT

Ezekiel does not mainly speak. He is made into a demonstration — positioned, restricted, silenced, and bereaved so that his body becomes the message. No other prophetic book does this at this scale. **[C]**

THE CALL AND THE WHEELS · 1–3

A storm from the north, four living creatures with four faces, wheels that move without turning, eyes on the rims, and above it a likeness of a throne with a likeness of a human figure on it. The vocabulary is relentlessly hedged — likeness, appearance, something like — because the point is that this cannot be reported plainly. Then he is handed a scroll and told to eat it, and it tastes sweet. **[C]**

THE GLORY LEAVES · 8–11, RETURNS 43

He is shown what is being done inside the temple, and then the divine presence moves — from the inner sanctuary, to the threshold, to the east gate, out of the city. It is a staged withdrawal, recorded like a departure route. Thirty-two chapters later it comes back to a rebuilt house by the same gate. The building was never the point; the presence was. **[C]**

THE SYMBOLIC PERFORMANCES · 4–5, 12

He lies on one side, then the other, for a counted number of days. He eats a measured siege ration. He shaves his head and beard and divides the hair. He digs through a wall and carries out a packed bag at dusk like a refugee. Public, humiliating, sustained — performance art commissioned as prophecy. **[C]**

THE DEATH OF HIS WIFE · 24:15–27

She is called the delight of his eyes. He is told in advance that she will die, and told not to mourn her publicly — no weeping, no rites — because his withheld grief is the sign of what is coming to the city. She dies; he does as instructed. The text names her only by his relation to her, gives her no words, and uses her death as an illustration. Whatever else this book is, it is a book that does that. **[C]**

WHAT THE EMPIRE WOULD DO WITH A LICENSED PROPHET WHOSE BODY IS THE BROADCAST

CONTENT PREPARATION

This page discusses two extended prophetic allegories that describe women's bodies in explicit sexual terms and depict stripping, public exposure, mutilation, and killing as deserved punishment for infidelity. It does not quote them. You may work this page later, or not at all, and the spread still functions.

THE METAPHOR THAT USES A WOMAN'S BODY

WHAT THEY ARE	Two long allegories. Chapter 16 casts Jerusalem as a foundling raised, adorned, married, and then unfaithful. Chapter 23 casts Samaria and Jerusalem as two sisters whose political alliances are described as sexual pursuit of foreign soldiers. **[C]**
THE ARGUMENT	Political alliance with imperial powers is figured as adultery, and the coming military destruction is figured as a husband's punishment of a wife — carried out by her former lovers, with divine authorization. The theology and the violence are not separable here; the violence *is* the argument. **[C]**
WHY IT MATTERS	These chapters have been read aloud, preached, and taught for millennia with the gendered violence treated as decoration on a spiritual point. A great deal of modern scholarship — feminist criticism in particular — argues the imagery cannot be treated as incidental, and that its long use has consequences for how women hear divine judgment. Present that as a serious body of scholarship, not a fringe complaint. **[R]**
READINGS ON OFFER	That the metaphor indicts a *city* and its leadership, not women. That it draws on covenant-treaty language where infidelity is the standard charge. That the shock is the intended rhetorical effect. That the imagery is harmful regardless of intent and should not be reproduced without saying so. These are not mutually exclusive, and none of them makes the text safe. **[R]**
THE COMPANION'S RULE	Name what the text does. Do not quote it to shock. Do not soften it into "unfaithfulness." Do not treat centuries of preaching on it as a neutral fact. **[P]**

WHY THIS IS DIRECTLY TKC

Dominion already treats a woman's body as the site where a household's loyalty is measured, and already stages exposure as correction. It does not need to invent a scriptural warrant — it has one, at length, in a major prophet. The question for your Empire is not whether it would use these chapters. It is whether it quotes them or keeps them for the closed catechism. **[P]**

MY OWN POSITION — WRITE IT DOWN ONCE, HERE, SO THE MANUSCRIPT IS CONSISTENT

EZEK 16

EZEK 23

HOS 1–3 (COMPARE)

MCCARTHY, TREATY AND COVENANT

WEEMS, BATTERED LOVE · GALAMBUSH, JERUSALEM IN EZEKIEL

TKC: DOM · MEN

EZEK 18

EXOD 20.5

LAM 5.7

EZEK 34

EZEK 37 .1–14

EZEK 38–39

EZEK 40–48

AFTER THE CITY FALLS

WHOSE FAULT · 18

The chapter quotes a proverb the exiles are using — parents ate sour grapes and the children's teeth are set on edge — and rejects it: the person who sins is the one who bears it, and a person who turns is not held to their record. Read this against the second commandment's language of generational visitation, against Lamentations' complaint that the children bear the parents' guilt, and against Ezekiel's own account of a whole city destroyed together. The Bible does not speak with one voice here, and the disagreement is the material. **[R]**

THE SHEPHERDS · 34

An indictment of rulers who fed themselves on the flock — wore the wool, ate the fat, did not strengthen the weak or heal the sick or search for the lost, and ruled with force. The chapter removes them, and God takes the work personally: searching, gathering, feeding, binding up, judging between the fat sheep and the lean. Then it promises a single shepherd, named as "my servant David." So the remedy is neither better management nor the permanent absence of a shepherd — the office is emptied, worked directly, and then refilled on God's terms. **[C]** This is the most quotable anti-leadership passage in the prophets, and the hardest one for an institution to circulate safely. **[P]**

THE VALLEY OF DRY BONES · 37

He is set in a valley of bones and asked whether they can live; he answers that God knows. The bones reassemble, and breath enters them. The text then interprets itself: these bones are the whole house of Israel, and the vision is about a people who believe they are finished. It is not, in context, a passage about individual life after death — later traditions read it that way, and the reading has its own history. Keep the two apart. **[R]**

GOG AND MAGOG · 38–39

A vast future invasion from the north, defeated. Later apocalyptic and modern political preaching have both mined these chapters heavily for identifications of the enemy. Note the pattern rather than adopting it: the naming of a final enemy is a durable political technology. **[R]**

THE MEASURED TEMPLE · 40–48

Nine chapters of specification: gates, courts, chambers, altar, priestly duties, festival calendar, a river running out of the sanctuary, and a redivided land. A priest in exile responds to catastrophe with a building plan and a rota. Whether it is a blueprint, a vision, or a protest against the temple that failed is debated. What it plainly is: hope written as an ordinance. **[R]**

DOES DOMINION INHERIT GUILT BY HOUSEHOLD OR BY PERSON — AND DOES IT SAY THE SAME THING TWICE?

WHAT I TAKE OUT OF EZEKIEL

WRITING

SPREAD CLOSE

QUEUE: F3

THE DEPARTING PRESENCE — WHERE THIS BELONGS IN THE FALL, AND WHO NOTICES IT LEAVING

A CHARACTER WHOSE BODY IS BEING USED AS SOMEONE ELSE'S MESSAGE

WHAT I STILL DO NOT UNDERSTAND — CARRY TO THE RESEARCH LIST

PROMOTION REVIEW

log only — no promotion is made here

The audit assigns Ezekiel Focused tier with promotion available, and this is the likeliest promotion in the Bible queue. Promote if two or more hold: the departing-glory sequence becomes a structural motif rather than an image · chapters 16 and 23 become part of the Empire's actual catechism on the page · the exile material feeds the Fall directly · the shepherds oracle becomes something a character quotes.

DECISION | DATE | PAGES NEEDED

NOTES

OPEN
NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

F7

COLLECTIVE FOCUSED STUDY

THE TWELVE

One scroll, twelve arguments, four centuries, and three empires

SOURCE MARGIN

HOS–MAL

MT · LXX

NOGALSKI, THE BOOK OF THE TWELVE

SWEENEY, THE TWELVE PROPHETS

PLATE RESERVED

The Twelve plate not yet supplied — one scroll, twelve seams; a locust field; a city gate at dusk. Drop art here.

UNFINISHED · ART PENDING

COLLECTIVE STUDY F7 · ◈

THE TWELVE

Twelve short books copied onto one scroll and counted as one. Read as a set they cover the rise and fall of two kingdoms under three empires — and no two of them are making the same argument.

WHY COLLECTIVE, AND WHY NOW

Twelve individual dossiers would be disproportionate before you have read them. This study introduces the set, keeps each book's own setting and argument intact, and exists so that *you* decide which ones earn promotion — not the audit, and not me.

CONTENT PREPARATION

T04 covers Hosea's marriage metaphor, including sexual accusation and gendered violence. T06 covers the celebration of a city's destruction. Both are marked on the page.

ONE BOOK OR TWELVE

THE NAME	In Jewish tradition, *the Twelve* — one book. "Minor prophets" is a later Latin convention referring to *length*, not importance. If the word "minor" has ever made you skip them, that is the convention working. **[C]**
ONE SCROLL	Twelve books of this size fit on a single scroll, and they were counted as one book in ancient lists. Whether they were also *edited* as one collection — with deliberate links between the seams — is an active scholarly argument, not a settled result. **[R]**
THE ORDER VARIES	The Hebrew order and the Greek order differ in the first six books. So the sequence you are reading is a choice someone made, and any argument built on the arrangement depends on which arrangement. **[C]**
NOT CHRONOLOGICAL	The printed order is not the historical order. Amos and Hosea belong to the eighth century; Haggai, Zechariah, and Malachi to the Persian period after the return. Reading straight through gives you four centuries out of sequence. **[C]**
DATING	Some books date themselves precisely by reign; some are dated only by internal evidence; a few (Joel, Obadiah, Malachi) are genuinely uncertain. Do not print a date for those three as though it were given. **[R]**

WHAT THE SET GIVES YOU THAT THE MAJOR PROPHETS DO NOT

Twelve different answers to the same conditions. A prophet inside the court and one who denies being a prophet at all; a book that celebrates an empire's fall and a book furious that an empire was spared; a demand for justice and a demand for a building. Read as a set, the Twelve is the Bible arguing with itself in public. **[P]**

WHICH OF THE TWELVE I COULD NAME BEFORE THIS PAGE, AND WHICH I COULD NOT

HOS 1.1

MAL 4.6

MT ORDER · LXX ORDER

NOGALSKI, BOOK OF THE TWELVE

SWEENEY, TWELVE PROPHETS

2 KGS 14–25

EZRA 1–6

SWEENEY, TWELVE PROPHETS

TKC: TL

WHO WAS IN POWER WHEN

Prophecy is addressed to a situation. Without the empire on the horizon, every one of these books reads as generalized scolding. Placements below follow mainstream scholarship; the three marked uncertain are genuinely open. **[R]**

BOOK	SETTING	THE POWER IN THE ROOM
Amos	Northern kingdom, 8th c.	Prosperity before Assyria arrives. A Judean speaking in the north.
Hosea	Northern kingdom, 8th c.	Assyrian pressure and internal collapse; the north falls within his horizon.
Micah	Judah, 8th c.	Assyrian campaigns; a rural voice against the capital.
Nahum	Judah, 7th c.	Assyria's capital about to fall, or newly fallen.
Zephaniah	Judah, 7th c.	Late Assyrian period; addressed to Jerusalem's officials and merchants.
Habakkuk	Judah, late 7th c.	Babylon rising and named as the instrument.
Haggai	Judah, Persian period	Dated precisely by month and year of a Persian king. Temple rebuilding.
Zechariah	Judah, Persian period	Same moment as Haggai in its opening chapters; the later chapters are widely held to be later material.
Jonah	Set in the Assyrian era	Set then; generally thought to be written considerably later, looking back. **[R]**
Joel	Uncertain	No king named. Placements range widely. Say "uncertain" and mean it. **[R]**
Obadiah	Uncertain	Most often tied to the aftermath of Jerusalem's fall, on internal evidence. **[R]**
Malachi	Persian period	A functioning temple with slack practice. No king named; the title may be a role rather than a name. **[R]**

WHICH ERA MY EMPIRE IS IN — RISING, PEAKING, OR BEING NAMED AS THE INSTRUMENT

CONTENT PREPARATION · HOSEA

The Hosea entry below concerns a marriage metaphor built on sexual accusation, public exposure, and violence against a wife. It does not quote the imagery.

HOSEA

NORTHERN KINGDOM · 8TH C.

A prophet instructed to marry, and three children given names that are the message: one a place of slaughter, one meaning *not pitied*, one meaning *not my people*. The book then runs the nation's covenant failure through the figure of a wife accused of infidelity, with stripping, drought, and public shaming as the announced punishment, alongside some of the tenderest reconciliation language in scripture. **[C]**

CORRECTION "A God who keeps taking the nation back" is too soft to carry this book. It is accurate to the reconciliation passages and silent about the mechanism — and the mechanism is a husband's authorized violence. Say both, or say neither. **[P]**

STUDY the marriage metaphor · Gomer as a person and as a device · the children's names · covenant · sexual accusation · gendered violence · the reversal of the names at the end.

JOEL

SETTING UNCERTAIN

A locust invasion described in military language, a call to communal lament, and then a promise of restoration and of the divine spirit poured out on the whole community. No king is named and no empire is identified, which is why the book will not date. **[R]**

VERIFY IN TRANSLATION the outpouring passage names sons and daughters, old and young, and a third group whose rendering differs sharply between translations — some read household servants, some read enslaved men and women. Check at least three translations and a lexicon before quoting it, because the social claim changes with the choice. **[R]**

STUDY the locusts · the Day of the LORD · communal lament as procedure · restoration · the reuse of this passage in Acts.

AMOS

SPEAKS IN THE NORTH · 8TH C.

Oracles against the surrounding nations that circle inward until they land on Israel itself; then sustained attack on the sale of the poor, the seizure of garments and grain, and worship offered by people who are doing it. Confronted at the royal sanctuary by the priest Amaziah and told to go home, he answers with a statement about what he is and is not. **[C]**

CORRECTION "A farmer from the wrong kingdom" needs unpacking on two counts. He describes himself as a herdsman and a worker of sycamore figs — livestock and orchard work, not subsistence farming, and possibly a man of some means. **[C]** His answer to Amaziah is commonly read as denying membership in the professional prophetic guild rather than claiming rural poverty; the Hebrew is terse and much argued, and that he categorically denies all professional prophetic affiliation is a proposed reading, not settled. **[P]** He is also from Judah, speaking in the northern kingdom, which is a jurisdiction problem as much as a class one. **[C]**

STUDY the nations sequence · debt and the sale of persons · luxury and ivory beds · worship rejected · the Amaziah confrontation · the plumb line and the basket of fruit · the closing restoration verses and how they sit against the rest.

WHICH OF THESE THREE I WANT IN THE MANUSCRIPT, AND IN WHOSE MOUTH

HOS 1–3

WEEMS, BATTERED LOVE

JOEL 2.28–29

ACTS 2 .16–21

AMOS 7.10–17

AMOS 2.6–8

SWEENEY, TWELVE PROPHETS

OBAD 10–14

PS 137 (COMPARE)

JONAH 4

2 KGS 14.25

MIC 2 .1–2

MIC 3 .5–11

MIC 6.8

RAABE, OBADIAH (AB)

OBADIAH

SETTING UNCERTAIN · SHORTEST BOOK

One chapter against Edom, a neighboring people condemned for what it did on the day Jerusalem fell: standing aloof, gloating over the disaster, entering the gate and joining the plunder, cutting down fugitives at the crossroads, and handing over the survivors. Edom is not portrayed as leading Babylon's invasion — it is charged with every item on that list. **[C]**

STUDY Edom in the family stories and in the prophets · the day of a city's fall · bystanding as a named offense · profiting from a neighbor's catastrophe · what the shortest book in the Bible chooses to spend its one chapter on.

JONAH

SET IN THE ASSYRIAN ERA

A prophet who receives a commission and sails the opposite way; a storm; sailors who behave better than he does; the fish; a five-word sermon; a mass repentance including the livestock; and a prophet furious that it worked. It ends on a question about mercy that is never answered. **[C]**

CORRECTION "Satire" is one major genre classification and a useful one — the exaggeration, the repenting animals, the sulking prophet. It is not a settled fact, and other readings (parable, didactic novella, prophetic legend) are held seriously. Name it as a classification, not as the book's identity. **[R]**

STUDY mercy extended to an enemy empire · nationalism · prophetic refusal · Nineveh as a real capital and as a symbol · repentance from the throne down · the plant, the worm, and the unanswered final question.

MICAH

JUDAH · 8TH C.

Judgment on both capitals, and a specific economic charge: people who lie awake devising how to take fields and houses, and who then take them, because they have the power. Rulers who hate justice, judges who take bribes, priests who teach for a price, and prophets who tell you it is peace as long as you are feeding them. Then, in the same book, the promised ruler from a small town and the famous line about what is required. **[C]**

CORRECTION Micah is not reducible to its one quotable verse. Reading only that line removes the land seizure, the bought clergy, the threat against the capital, and the fact that the verse is the *answer* to a question about what an offering can buy. Study the argument it concludes. **[P]**

STUDY land seizure · rulers and judges · prophets for hire · the threat against Zion · Bethlehem · the courtroom framing of chapter 6 · judgment and restoration held together.

A PROPHET WHO IS ANGRY THAT MERCY WAS EXTENDED — DOES DOMINION HAVE ONE?

CONTENT PREPARATION · NAHUM

The Nahum entry concerns a poem that celebrates a city's destruction and uses sexualized humiliation of a personified capital as part of that celebration. It does not quote the imagery.

NAHUM JUDAH · 7TH C.

Three chapters on the fall of Assyria's capital, written in fast, visual, almost cinematic poetry — chariots in the streets, the sound of the whip, corpses piled — and a taunt song addressed to the city as a woman who is to be exposed before the nations. It is triumph, and it is poetry constructed for strong oral force. **[P]**

HOLD BOTH calling this a provincial revenge song dismisses the position it is written from: Assyria deported populations, flayed captives, and advertised it. This is the voice of people who were on the receiving end of a terror state, watching it end. That is not the same as a taste for cruelty. It is also not innocent — the gendered humiliation is doing real work, and the book's pleasure in the violence is not incidental. Study both without resolving them. **[P]**

STUDY Assyrian imperial practice · the poetics of a city's fall · who is permitted to celebrate · the personified capital · what the harmed are allowed to say · the opening hymn about patience and wrath.

HABAKKUK JUDAH · LATE 7TH C.

Structured as an argument. The prophet complains that violence goes unanswered; the reply names Babylon as the instrument; the prophet objects that this is worse; the second reply is a series of woes against the plunderer and a statement about the righteous living by faithfulness, with an instruction to write it down plainly and wait. The book closes with a psalm that chooses trust without claiming the situation has improved. **[C]**

CORRECTION "An unsatisfying answer" is this companion's verdict, not the book's. Remove it as description. What can be said plainly: the reply does not answer the question that was asked, and the book knows it — which is why it ends in waiting rather than in explanation. **[P]**

STUDY complaint as a legitimate prophetic form · God's use of an empire · the woes against the plunderer · the term rendered faith or faithfulness and its later reuse · waiting · the closing psalm.

ZEPHANIAH JUDAH · 7TH C.

A Day of the LORD announced as near, dark, and comprehensive — and aimed with unusual precision at officials, the royal household, traders, and people who have grown comfortable and assume nothing will happen. Then a promise that a remnant will be left: people described as lowly, who will not do wrong and will not be afraid. **[C]**

STUDY the Day of the LORD as a motif across the Twelve · the ruling class as the named target · complacency as an offense · the remnant and who it consists of · judgment and restoration in one short book · the closing promise of singing.

WHO IN MY WORLD IS ALLOWED TO CELEBRATE THE FALL, AND WHO IS TOLD IT IS UNSEEMLY

NAH 3 .1–7

WEEMS, BATTERED LOVE

HAB 1 –2.5

HAB 3

ZEPH 1 .7–13

ZEPH 3 .11–13

SWEENEY, TWELVE PROPHETS

HAG 1 .2–11

EZRA 5 .1–2

ZECH 1–6

ZECH 3

ZECH 9.9

MAL 2 .10–16

MAL 3.1 · 4.5–6

HUGENBERGER, MARRIAGE AS A COVENANT

HAGGAI

PERSIAN PERIOD · DATED PRECISELY

Four dated messages in a few months, all on one subject: the temple is a ruin while people live in finished houses. The economic argument is blunt — you sow much and harvest little, you earn wages and put them in a bag with holes — and it attributes the shortfall to the unbuilt house. The work restarts. Ezra names Haggai and Zechariah as the prophets who got it moving. **[C]**

STUDY temple rebuilding under imperial authorization · scarcity and its explanation · paneled houses against an unbuilt sanctuary · the leadership pair of governor and high priest · what religious construction costs ordinary households · the promise to the discouraged old who remembered the first house.

ZECHARIAH

PERSIAN PERIOD, AND LATER MATERIAL

Eight night visions with an interpreting messenger — horses and riders, a measuring line, a lampstand, a flying scroll, chariots — and a courtroom scene where the high priest stands in filthy clothes, is accused, and is re-dressed. Then oracles including a king who comes riding on a donkey, and a shepherd sequence that later Gospel writers draw on heavily. The second half of the book is widely held to be later material joined to the first. **[R]**

STUDY the night visions and how symbolic vision works · the priesthood restored by re-clothing · the governor and the two olive trees · the donkey-riding king · the pierced one and the struck shepherd · later reuse in the Gospels, read as reuse rather than as prediction fulfilled on schedule.

MALACHI

PERSIAN PERIOD

Built as a series of disputes: a claim is stated, the audience objects, and the objection is answered. The targets are priests offering defective animals; men described as acting treacherously against the wives of their youth, in a passage commonly read as addressing divorce but carrying real textual and translation difficulty; people withholding what is owed; and a general sense that serving God is not worth it. It promises a messenger who will refine the priesthood, and closes with Elijah and the turning of parents' and children's hearts toward each other. **[C]**

CORRECTION "The last word of the Old Testament is an accusation against clergy" works only in the Christian ordering — in the Jewish ordering Chronicles is last — and even then it is not accurate, because the book's closing verses are about Elijah and reconciliation within families, not about priests. Drop the claim. **[C]**

STUDY the dispute form · defective offerings and what they signal · the marriage and divorce passage, which is textually difficult and much argued · tithes and the storehouse · the messenger · the refiner · the Elijah ending.

A PROPHET WHOSE MESSAGE IS "FINISH THE BUILDING" — WHOSE INTERESTS DOES THAT SERVE?

WHICH PROPHETS AN EMPIRE KEEPS

MIC 3 .5–8

AMOS 5.21–24

HAG 1 .4–6

MAL 3 .8–10

HAB 2 .6–17

TKC: DOM · CT

The Twelve contains both kinds: prophets who tell an institution to finish its building, and prophets who tell an institution its worship is worthless while it sells the poor. Any empire that licenses a prophetic office is making a selection from exactly this range — and the selection is the doctrine. **[P]**

WHAT THE SANCTUM CIRCULATES	WHAT IT KEEPS IN THE CLOSED CATECHISM
Haggai — finish the house, and the shortfall is because you have not.	Micah — the people who lie awake planning how to take fields, and take them, because they can.
Malachi — bring the full tithe into the storehouse.	Malachi — the priests themselves are the first ones charged.
Hosea's reconciliation passages — the God who takes her back.	Hosea's mechanism — the exposure and the shaming that precede the taking back.
Zephaniah's remnant — the humble who are spared.	Zephaniah's target list — officials, the royal household, and the merchants.
Nahum — the enemy empire falls, because we are the righteous ones.	Habakkuk — the empire God is using is itself under judgment for the same violence.
Amos's closing restoration verses.	Everything in Amos before them, and the fact that a priest of the royal sanctuary told him to leave the country.

THE TEST THE TWELVE ACTUALLY OFFERS

Micah names prophets who declare peace as long as they are being fed, and trouble for anyone who stops feeding them. Read as an application, that yields a functional test rather than a moral one: follow the money and see whose interest the message serves. It works on the Sanctum, and on anyone your characters are inclined to trust — but it is an interpretive use of Micah, not something the text prescribes. **[P]**

THE SANCTUM'S APPROVED PROPHETIC CANON — LIST WHAT IS IN AND WHAT IS SEALED

WRITING

HOS–MAL

TKC: DOM · CT · TL

BUILD THE PROPHETIC OFFICE

Four pages of reference have given you twelve models. This page turns them into Dominion's institution.

1 · HOW A PERSON BECOMES A LICENSED PROPHET IN DOMINION — AND WHO REVOKES IT

2 · AN UNLICENSED VOICE WHO IS RIGHT — WHAT HAPPENS AT THE SANCTUARY DOOR

3 · THE EMPIRE'S OWN "DAY OF THE LORD" — WHAT IT PROMISES AND WHO IT THREATENS

4 · ONE ORACLE, IN FULL, IN THE SANCTUM'S VOICE — THEN THE SAME EVENT FROM OUTSIDE IT

WHICH OF THE TWELVE EARNS MORE

WRITING

STUDY
CLOSE

QUEUE:
F7

The audit names seven as likely to need individual focused study later: Hosea, Amos, Jonah, Micah, Habakkuk, Zechariah, and Malachi. It also says you should read this collective study before deciding. The audit-candidate column records the audit's seven; the Mark column is yours and is left blank. Mark the ones you want; nothing is promoted from this page.

BOOK	AUDIT CANDIDATE	MARK	WHY — ONE LINE
Hosea	AUDIT		
Joel			
Amos	AUDIT		
Obadiah			
Jonah	AUDIT		
Micah	AUDIT		
Nahum			
Habakkuk	AUDIT		
Zephaniah			
Haggai			
Zechariah	AUDIT		
Malachi	AUDIT		

WHAT I STILL DO NOT UNDERSTAND — CARRY TO THE RESEARCH LIST

PROMOTION REVIEW

log only — no promotion is made here

BOOKS MARKED | DATE | TIER PROPOSED

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS STUDY STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

OPEN
NOTES

SOURCE MARGIN

GEN 1–50

MT · LXX

ALTER, GENESIS (TRANS.)

UNFINISHED · ART PENDING



UNFINISHED — Genesis plate not yet supplied. Drop reference or Canva art here.

or browse files

DOSSIER I · ◈

GENESIS

The book Dominion quotes first and reads least. Everything the Empire claims about men, women, land, and order is traced back to fifty chapters that spend most of their length undermining exactly that claim.

WHY THIS ONE IS FIRST

It is the source of the Empire's founding doctrine and of your own earliest religious education. Both need excavating, and this dossier is the prototype for every one that follows.

HOW TO WORK IT

Reference is roughly a third of these pages. The rest is yours. A half-filled dossier is more useful than a blank one.

GEN 1.1

GEN 1–11

GEN 12–50

WESTERMANN, GENESIS 1–11

ENUMA ELISH · ATRAHASIS

TKC: TL

WHAT IT IS

NAME	Greek *genesis*, origin. Hebrew *bereshit*, "in the beginning" — Hebrew books are named for their first words, not their contents. **[C]**
PLACE	First book of the Torah in every collection. Nobody disputes its position; everything else about it is discussed. **[C]**
AUTHORSHIP	Traditionally Moses. Modern scholarship generally sees composite composition from multiple sources and periods, with substantial editing in or after the exile. The specifics — how many sources, which verses, what dates — are actively debated, and the debate is not settled. **[R]**
GENRES INSIDE	Cosmology, genealogy, etiology, family saga, legal precedent, poetry, dream report, and a novella-length court narrative in the Joseph material. Not one genre — do not run one test across all fifty chapters. **[C]**
STRUCTURE	Chapters 1–11, the primeval history: creation to the scattering of peoples. Chapters 12–50, the ancestral narratives: one family across four generations. The seam is visible and the two halves behave differently. **[C]**
NEIGHBORS	Mesopotamian creation and flood literature covers similar ground with different theology. Comparison is where Genesis's distinctive claims become visible rather than assumed. **[R]**

WHAT THE BOOK IS ACTUALLY ABOUT, IF IT IS ABOUT ONE THING

Blessing that keeps passing to the wrong person. Younger over elder, the barren over the fertile, the deceiver over the dutiful, the foreigner into the family. A book used to justify hierarchy spends fifty chapters disrupting the one hierarchy it names most — birth order. **[P]**

WHAT I ALREADY THINK THIS BOOK SAYS, BEFORE READING IT AGAIN

TWO ACCOUNTS, UNRECONCILED

GEN 1.1 –2.3

GEN 2.4 –25

BDB · HALOT ʿEZER

TRIBLE, RHETORIC OF SEXUALITY

ENUMA ELISH

The book opens with two creation accounts, in sequence, that differ in order, method, vocabulary, and image of God. The editors who assembled it left both. That decision is the first thing Genesis teaches about how scripture works. **[C]**

	FIRST ACCOUNT · 1:1–2:3	SECOND ACCOUNT · 2:4–25
SHAPE	Six ordered days, a liturgical refrain, resolving into rest.	A single scene: a garden, a river, a naming, a lack.
METHOD	Speech. God says, and it is.	Hands. God forms from soil, plants, breathes, builds.
ORDER	Plants, animals, then humanity — male and female together, last.	The man first, then plants, then animals, then the woman.
HUMANITY	In the image of God, both, blessed and given dominion over the earth — not over each other.	Formed from dust, given a garden to work and keep, then given a partner because solitude is called not good.
THE WORD FOR HER	No separate term. Both are *adam*, humanity.	A Hebrew phrase often rendered "helper suitable for him." The noun is used elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible mostly of God helping Israel, which is why "assistant" is a poor gloss and "helper" is doing more work than it looks. **[R]**

WHAT DOMINION DOES WITH THE PAIR

Teaches the second account as the operative one and the first as poetry. Order of creation becomes order of authority; "helper" becomes a job description; dominion over the earth quietly becomes dominion inside the household. None of it requires altering a word — only choosing which account is doctrine. **[P]**

WHICH ACCOUNT I WAS TAUGHT, AND WHICH ONE I HAD NEVER NOTICED WAS SEPARATE

GEN 1.26 –28

WORK THE DOCTRINE

GEN 2.15

Two doctrines come out of these three chapters and both are load-bearing for the Empire. Write them out in Dominion's voice before you write your objection — the Empire's version has to be genuinely persuasive or Eden's crisis is not a crisis.

THE IMAGE OF GOD — WHAT THE EMPIRE SAYS IT MEANS, AND WHO IT QUIETLY EXCLUDES

VON RAD, GENESIS

TKC: DOM

DOMINION AS STEWARDSHIP VERSUS DOMINION AS OWNERSHIP — THE EMPIRE'S ARGUMENT, AT ITS BEST

MY OBJECTION, IN ONE PARAGRAPH I WOULD DEFEND OUT LOUD

WHERE THIS LANDS IN THE MANUSCRIPT — SCENE, CHAPTER, OR CATECHISM

STATUS [C] [P] [?] [R] DECIDED LOG NO. DATE

THE PRIMEVAL HISTORY

Four movements, each ending worse than it began, each answered by a promise rather than a punishment. The pattern is the argument. **[P]**

THE GARDEN · GEN 3

The text says the ground is cursed and the serpent is cursed. It does not say the woman is cursed — it describes what her life will now contain, including that her desire will be for her husband and he will rule over her. Whether that line is prescription or diagnosis is one of the genuine disputes in the book, and the Empire has never once presented it as a dispute. **[R]**

THE FIRST KILLING · GEN 4

Violence enters within one generation of the garden, and God's response is a mark of protection rather than execution. The first city in the book is founded by the murderer. Genesis is not sentimental about civilization. **[C]**

THE FLOOD · GEN 6–9

Two interwoven strands are visible in the counting — pairs of animals and sevens, forty days and a hundred fifty. Mesopotamian flood narratives share the structure and differ sharply in why the flood happens and what it says about the divine. The account ends with a permanent one-sided commitment never to do it again, and the sign of that commitment is a weapon hung up in the sky. Comparison with the Mesopotamian versions is where its distinctive claims show. **[R]**

THE TOWER · GEN 11

A single people, a single language, and a building project undertaken so that they will not be scattered. The scattering happens anyway. Read against an empire that standardizes speech and centralizes construction, this is the most politically pointed chapter in the first eleven — and the one Dominion would find hardest to teach honestly. **[P]**

WHICH OF THE FOUR IS DOMINION'S FOUNDING MYTH, AND WHICH ONE IS ITS INDICTMENT

GEN 3.14–19

GEN 4.8–17

GEN 6–9

GILGAMESH XI · ATRAHASIS

GEN 11.1–9

WESTERMANN, GENESIS 1–11

GEN 12–25

GEN 24–27

GEN 29–35

GEN 37–50

GEN 47.13–26

SPEISER, GENESIS (ANCHOR)

FOUR GENERATIONS

One household carrying a promise it repeatedly endangers. Read the right column before writing anything about inheritance in the Empire.

GENERATION	WHAT HAPPENS	HOW THE ORDER BREAKS
Abraham & Sarah	Called to leave, promised land and descendants, and childless for decades. Sarah gives Hagar to Abraham; Hagar bears Ishmael and is driven out twice. A covenant, a near-sacrifice, and a burial plot that is the only land actually acquired.	The firstborn son is not the heir. The enslaved woman's child is given his own promise.
Isaac & Rebekah	The quietest generation. Rebekah receives the oracle about her twins directly and acts on it decisively.	The younger twin is designated before birth, and the mother engineers the outcome.
Jacob, Leah, Rachel	Deception in both directions, two sisters married to one man, four mothers of twelve sons, twenty years of labor, and a night of wrestling that leaves him renamed and limping.	The unloved wife bears most of the sons. The blessing arrives through a lie and is not withdrawn.
Joseph & brothers	Sold by his brothers, imprisoned on a false accusation, elevated to administer an empire's grain, and reunited with the family he can now feed or destroy.	The eleventh son governs. Judah, not Joseph, carries the royal line.

THE JOSEPH MATERIAL IS AN ADMINISTRATION STORY TKC

A famine is forecast, grain is centralized, and over the course of the crisis the population sells its livestock, then its land, then itself into servitude to the crown in exchange for food. The narrative reports it without visible criticism, as competent administration. It is also the mechanism by which a free population becomes a labor force, and Exodus opens on the consequence. Whether Genesis intends any judgment on it is a reading the text does not settle. **[P]**

WHICH DOMINION POLICY IS THE JOSEPH ADMINISTRATION, AND WHO IN THE EMPIRE ADMIRES HIM

SEVEN PROMISES

The book's spine is a promise restated seven times, each time to someone with less standing to receive it and each time with a different sign attached. Note what is asked in return: for most of them, almost nothing. **[C]**

TO WHOM	WHAT IS PROMISED, AND WHAT IS ASKED	THE SIGN
Noah and every living thing	Never again. Made with all flesh, not one people, and nothing is required in return — the only unconditional promise in the book.	A bow in the cloud
Abram the call	Land, descendants, and blessing that reaches all families of the earth. Asked: leave. The blessing is outward-facing from the first sentence.	None. Only the going
Abram the night ceremony	Offspring like the stars, and land. God alone passes between the divided animals, which in treaty terms means God alone bears the penalty for breach.	Fire between the pieces
Abraham and Sarah renamed	Nations, kings, everlasting covenant. Asked: circumcision — a mark on the body, borne by the household including the enslaved.	Flesh
Hagar twice, in the wilderness	Descendants too many to count, and a son who will live. She is enslaved, foreign, and expelled — and receives a promise in the same terms as the patriarch's.	A well, and a name for God
Jacob fleeing, at Bethel	The same promise, restated to a man running from the brother he cheated. Nothing is asked and nothing is withdrawn.	A stone, and a stairway
Judah in the deathbed blessing	Rule, and a scepter that does not depart. Given to the fourth son, who sold his brother and was corrected by Tamar — not to Joseph, who governed an empire.	Words only

GEN 9. 8–17

GEN 12. 1–3

GEN 15

GEN 17

GEN 22. 15–18

GEN 28. 10–22

GEN 49

ANE SUZERAIN TREATIES

THE STRUCTURE UNDERNEATH HIST · TREATY FORM

The ceremony in chapter 15 borrows the form of an ancient political treaty between a greater and a lesser power — and then inverts the crucial term, because the greater power walks the path alone. Whether that inversion is the point is a reading, and it is a well-supported one. **[R]**

WHICH PROMISE DOMINION CLAIMS TO STAND ON — AND WHICH TERMS IT OMITS TO DO SO

GEN 16 · 21.10 –13

GEN 25. 29–34

GEN 27

GEN 35. 22 · 49.3–4

GEN 38 · RUTH 4. 18–22

TKC: TL · MEN

WHO INHERITS, AND WHY NOT

Four generations, and the line never once runs through the person it legally should. Fill the last column: the Empire runs on birth order, and this is the book it says it runs on.

THE LINE, AS THE BOOK GIVES IT

Terah → **Abram / Abraham** + Sarai / Sarah · + Hagar · + Keturah

Ishmael (firstborn, by Hagar — promised, not chosen)

Isaac (second son, by Sarah — chosen) + Rebekah

Esau (firstborn twin — sells it, then loses it)

Jacob / Israel (second twin, designated in the womb)

by **Leah**: Reuben, Simeon, Levi, **Judah**, Issachar, Zebulun · Dinah

by **Rachel**: Joseph, Benjamin

by **Bilhah**: Dan, Naphtali · by **Zilpah**: Gad, Asher

Judah + **Tamar** → Perez → the royal line, by way of Ruth

GENERATION	WHO SHOULD HAVE INHERITED, AND WHO DID	THE TKC PARALLEL
First	Ishmael by birth; Isaac by promise. The displaced son still receives a nation.	
Second	Esau by birth; Jacob by oracle, appetite, and deception. Nobody unwinds it afterward.	
Third	Reuben by birth; Judah by default, after his three elder brothers disqualify themselves.	
Fourth	Joseph by favor and competence; Judah by blessing. Power and lineage part company at the end of the book.	

WHERE THE VANE SUCCESSION SITS ON THIS PAGE — AND WHO IS THE ISHMAEL OF THAT HOUSE

SIX WOMEN, SIX MECHANISMS

Genesis is unusually attentive to women without being kind to them. Each of these six operates inside a system that gives her no formal power, and each finds a different lever. This is the page the character work comes from.

WHO	WHAT SHE DOES, AND WHAT IT COSTS	THE LEVER
Hagar	Enslaved, given to Abraham without consent, driven into the wilderness twice. She is the first person in the book to name God, and she does it alone.	None. She has none, and is met anyway.
Sarah	Barren for decades, twice passed off as Abraham's sister to protect him, and the one who insists Hagar and Ishmael be expelled. Laughs at the promise, then names her son for laughter.	Household authority, used against a woman with less.
Rebekah	Consulted about her own marriage, given the oracle directly, and the architect of the blessing's redirection. Never sees her favored son again.	Information, and the willingness to act on it first.
Leah	Married by deception to a man who wanted her sister, and unloved for the rest of her life. Bears six of the twelve, names them after her grief, and is buried in the family tomb where Rachel is not.	Endurance, and the naming of sons.
Dinah	Assaulted, then used as the pretext for a massacre carried out by her brothers in the language of family honor. She does not speak once in the chapter.	Silence — the text's, not hers.
Tamar	Denied the levirate marriage owed to her, she disguises herself, takes Judah's pledge as evidence, and produces it when he sentences her to death. He concedes she is more righteous than he is.	Documentation. She keeps the receipt.

THE PATTERN WORTH TAKING TKC

Every one of them works the system rather than escaping it, and the two who win outright — Rebekah and Tamar — win with information and evidence. Eden's entire method is on this page, and so is the reason Celeste taught her to keep something unregistered. **[P]**

WHICH OF THE SIX IS EDEN, WHICH IS CELESTE, AND WHICH IS THE ONE NOBODY IN TKC HAS BEEN YET

GEN 16.13

GEN 18 · 21

GEN 25.23 27

GEN 29 –30

GEN 34

GEN 38.26

FRYMER-KENSKY, READING THE WOMEN OF THE BIBLE

YOURS

ONE WOMAN, ALL THE WAY DOWN

Pick one from the facing page and work her fully. Do not pick the one you already have an opinion about.

SHE IS

PASSAGES

↩ VOL I WOMEN OF THE TEXT

WHAT THE TEXT SAYS SHE DOES — AND WHAT IT DECLINES TO SAY ABOUT IT

WHAT SHE IS REDUCED TO IN SERMONS AND STUDY NOTES

WHAT DOMINION WOULD TEACH ABOUT HER TO GIRLS AT DESIGNATION AGE

THE SCENE SHE UNLOCKS — AND WHO IN THE PARISH HOUSEHOLD HAS LIVED IT

STATUS [C] [P] [?] [R]

DECIDED

LOG NO.

DATE

SIX FAULT LINES

Sorted by the four kinds of disagreement from the Contested Readings section: **I** scholarly, **II** denominational, **III** open theological, **IV** unsupported.

THE DISPUTE	KIND	WHAT IS ACTUALLY AT STAKE
The image of God	III	Whether it names a capacity, a status, a function, or a relationship — and whether it is held individually or only jointly. The text does not define it, and every definition since has been an argument about who qualifies.
"He shall rule over you"	I	Prescription or description. Read as prescription it establishes hierarchy by divine decree; read as description it reports a consequence the rest of scripture works against. Hebrew grammar permits both, and specialists divide.
The curse of Ham	IV	The text curses Canaan, not Ham, says nothing about skin, and was retrofitted centuries later to justify racial slavery. Not a contested reading. A documented misuse, and the most important thing in this book for TKC to get exactly right.
Sodom	II	What the city is condemned for. Later biblical references name arrogance, excess, and refusal of the needy; the narrative itself centers a violent demand against guests under protection. Traditions differ, and the differences are confessional as much as textual.
The binding of Isaac	III	A test passed, a test failed, a polemic against child sacrifice, or an unresolved horror the text refuses to soften. Sarah is not consulted and never speaks to Abraham again in the narrative.
Genre of ch. 1–11	II	Whether these chapters are historical report, theological narrative, or something the ancient category system does not divide the way we do. Communities differ, and the difference drives most modern conflict over the book.

THE ONE TO HANDLE WITH BOTH HANDS

Row three. A category IV claim built into centuries of law and preaching is exactly the kind of thing Dominion would still be teaching, and exactly the kind of thing a novel must not reproduce carelessly while depicting. Write the Empire believing it; do not let the companion be vague about its falsity. **[C]**

WHICH OF THE SIX DOMINION TEACHES AS SETTLED, AND WHO IN THE EMPIRE KNOWS OTHERWISE

GEN 1.27

GEN 3.16

GEN 9. 20–27

GOLDENBERG, THE CURSE OF HAM

GEN 19 · EZEK 16.49

GEN 22

LEVENSON, BELOVED SON

METHOD
↩ 008

RUN THE EIGHT

One Genesis passage, all eight questions, plus two translations side by side. Suggested first run: the sentence about ruling in chapter three.

PASSAGE

TRANSLATIONS

[R] IF GREEK OR HEBREW CLAIMED

1 · GENRE

2 · SPEAKER

3 · AUDIENCE

4 · BEFORE & AFTER

5 · WHAT WORLD PRODUCED IT

6 · WHAT THE WORDS DO — AND WHERE THE TWO TRANSLATIONS PART

THE TWO RENDERINGS, COPIED OUT WORD FOR WORD

> *Questions seven and eight — who gains, and what it costs — are on the facing page. They need more room than the first six, and they are the two Dominion has never asked out loud.*

WHO GAINS, WHO PAYS

The last two questions, with room to answer them properly, plus the record of what the run produced. Nothing on this spread is canon until the final row is filled.

7 · WHO GAINS FROM EACH READING — NAME THEM, INCLUDING WHERE YOU BENEFIT

8 · WHAT EACH READING COSTS, AND WHO PAYS IT

DOMINION'S READING

WHERE I CURRENTLY LAND

WHAT STILL NEEDS A REAL SOURCE — LEXICON, COMMENTARY, OR MANUSCRIPT NOTE

THE SCENE, CHAPTER, OR DOCTRINE THIS FEEDS

STATUS [C] [P] [?] [R]

DECIDED

LOG NO.

DATE

EX 1.8–14

EZEK 16.49

RUTH 4.18–22

MATT 1.1–17

ROM 4 · 5.12–21 GAL 3

1 TIM 2.11–15

REV 22.1–5

WHO USED IT NEXT

Genesis is quoted, argued with, and rewritten across the rest of the collection. Every later use is somebody deciding what the book meant — which is exactly what Dominion does, only with a printing press and a lectionary.

WHO, AND WHERE	WHAT THEY DO WITH IT
Exodus	Opens on the consequence of the Joseph administration: the descendants of the man who centralized the grain are the forced labor. The two books are one argument, and almost nobody teaches them that way.
The prophets	Reach back to Abraham and to Sodom as precedent — and Ezekiel names Sodom's sin as pride, plenty, and refusing the poor. That is a reading of Genesis printed inside the Bible.
Ruth	Closes by tracing David's line through Perez — Tamar's son. The genealogy argues that the line has always run through outsiders and irregular unions.
Matthew	Opens the New Testament with a Genesis genealogy and puts Tamar in it by name, alongside Ruth and Rahab. A deliberate editorial choice about who belongs.
Paul	Uses Abraham to argue the promise preceded the law, and Adam as a pattern for Christ. Reading Genesis as precedent for a present controversy — the same move Dominion makes, aimed differently.
The Pastorals	Cite the order of creation and the deception in the garden as grounds for restricting women's teaching. The single most consequential later use of Genesis 2–3 for anyone in TKC.
Revelation	Ends the collection by reversing the opening — a garden restored inside a city, the tree accessible, the serpent finished. Genesis is the book the last book is answering.

INTERPRETIVE AFTERLIVES, BRIEFLY

Jewish midrash treats the gaps as invitations and argues in the margins for centuries. Christian allegory reads the garden forward into doctrine. The Reformation reads it for law and grace. Modern criticism asks who wrote it and when. Each tradition answers a different question, and none of them reads it cold. **[R]**

WHICH LATER USE DOMINION INHERITED WITHOUT KNOWING IT WAS AN INTERPRETATION

WHAT WAS DONE WITH IT

GOLDENBERG, THE CURSE OF HAM

GEN 9. 20–27

GEN 2–3 · 1 TIM 2. 11–15

GEN 1.28

GEN 3.16

HIST: RECEPTION

Four documented misuses, named plainly. These are not contested readings — they are historical uses of this book to justify harm, and a novel about an empire built on scripture has to know them precisely enough not to reproduce them by accident. **[C]**

I · THE SO-CALLED CURSE OF HAM

The passage curses Canaan, not Ham, and says nothing whatever about skin or race. It was attached to African peoples and used to underwrite slavery and segregation for centuries, in sermons, statutes, and schoolbooks. The misreading is documented and traceable, and the text does not support it.

II · ORDER OF CREATION AS PERMANENT RANK

Made second, therefore subordinate; deceived first, therefore untrustworthy. Built by reading the second creation account as a hierarchy chart and setting the first aside — and used to bar women from teaching, testifying, holding property, and holding office.

III · DOMINION AS LICENSE

A grant of stewardship over the earth converted into a warrant for extraction, conquest, and the taking of inhabited land. The verse concerns creatures and soil; it says nothing about authority over other peoples.

IV · CHILDBEARING AS SENTENCE

Pain in childbirth read as a penalty properly borne, and used to refuse women relief, medical and otherwise. A line describing loss, enforced as a divine requirement.

HOW TO WRITE THESE

Let Dominion hold them sincerely and argue them well — that is what makes the Empire frightening rather than cartoonish. Do not let the companion be vague about whether they are true. Sincerity and falsity are both required, and they belong on different pages.

WHICH OF THE FOUR IS LAW IN DOMINION, AND WHO TEACHES IT BELIEVING IT

WHAT THE EMPIRE TOOK

Four doctrines Dominion draws from this book, each traceable to a verse and each requiring the rest of the chapter to be left out. Fill the right column with the instrument from the six — calendar, readings, clergy access, schoolbooks, provincial editions, or commentary.

DOCTRINE	WHAT HAS TO BE OMITTED FOR IT TO HOLD	INSTRUMENT
Order of the household	The first creation account entirely, and the fact that the ruling sentence appears in a description of loss rather than a design specification.	
Fruitfulness as duty	That the blessing is given to humanity jointly, and that four of the book's central women are infertile for most of their lives without being judged for it.	
Dominion itself	That the grant is over the earth and its creatures, never over other people — and that the Empire's own name is taken from a verse that does not authorize it.	
Order restored after collapse	That the flood story ends with a promise never to do it again, which makes divine catastrophe a poor template for a state that stages one.	

THE NAME PROBLEM TKC

The Empire calls its provinces Dominions after a verse about stewardship of the earth. Someone chose that word deliberately, and somebody in the founding generation knew what it actually said. That person is worth locating — and it is not a decision to make on this page. **[?]**

WHO NAMED THE DOMINIONS, AND WHETHER IT WAS PIETY OR A JOKE

YOURS

WHAT CHANGED

Close every dossier the same way: what you believed, what you found, what is still open, and what is now canon. Nothing on the preceding pages is canon until it appears in the last box and the log.

PART IX
LOG

WHAT I BELIEVED ABOUT GENESIS BEFORE THIS DOSSIER

WHAT SURPRISED ME — AND WHY SURPRISE IS NOT YET EVIDENCE

WHAT STAYS OPEN, AND WHAT I NEED A REAL SOURCE FOR

WHAT I AM MAKING CANON FROM THIS BOOK — AND THE LOG NUMBER IT GETS

STATUS [C] [P] [?] [R] DECIDED LOG NO. DATE

SOURCE MARGIN

EXOD 1–40

MT · LXX

PROPP, EXODUS (AB)

CHILDS, EXODUS (OTL)

PLATE RESERVED

Exodus plate not yet supplied — a brick tally, a river at night, a mountain under cloud. Drop art here.

UNFINISHED · ART PENDING

DOSSIER II · ◈

EXODUS

The book every liberation movement has quoted and every empire has learned to quote back. It does not end at the sea. Two thirds of it is what happens after the escape — law, labor, ritual, and a people arguing with the God who brought them out.

WHY A FULL DOSSIER

Dominion's entire deliverance liturgy is built on this book, and so is every argument against it. The audit assigns a full dossier and warns against stopping at the escape. This one does not.

HOW TO WORK IT

Reference is roughly a third of these pages. The rest is yours. A half-filled dossier is more useful than a blank one.

WHAT IT IS

NAME	Greek *exodos*, a going out. Hebrew *Shemot*, "names," from the opening line listing the names of those who came down to Egypt. The Greek title names the event; the Hebrew title names the people. **[C]**
PLACE	Second book of the Torah, and the hinge of it: a family becomes a people, a people becomes a nation with law. Genesis ends with a household in Egypt; Exodus opens with a labor force. **[C]**
AUTHORSHIP	Traditionally Moses. Modern scholarship generally sees composite composition and substantial editing, with the law collections and the tabernacle material widely treated as distinct bodies of text. Which verses belong to which hand, and when, is actively debated and not settled. **[R]**
HISTORICITY	There is no direct external documentation of the departure as the book describes it, and proposals about date, scale, and route vary widely. The companion treats the narrative as scripture and as literature, and does not print any reconstruction as established history. **[R]**
STRUCTURE	Chapters 1–15, oppression and departure. Chapters 16–18, the wilderness and the first administration. Chapters 19–24, Sinai, the Decalogue, and the covenant code. Chapters 25–40, the sanctuary instructions, interrupted by the calf. The escape is a third of the book. **[C]**
GENRES INSIDE	Narrative, genealogy, plague cycle, victory poetry, case law, apodictic command, ritual calendar, and construction specification. The tabernacle chapters are an architectural document. Do not read them the way you read chapter 14. **[C]**
NEIGHBORS	Ancient Near Eastern law collections, the Laws of Hammurabi among them, cover much of the same legal ground in the same case form. Reading the covenant code beside them shows what is conventional in it and what is not. **[R]**

WHAT THE BOOK IS ACTUALLY ABOUT, IF IT IS ABOUT ONE THING

Who owns the labor of a people, and what a people owes the one who freed them. The question does not close when they leave Egypt — it becomes the law, and then the argument, and then the sanctuary. **[P]**

WHAT I ALREADY THINK THIS BOOK SAYS, BEFORE READING IT AGAIN

EXOD 1.1

EXOD 1–15

EXOD 19–24

EXOD 25–40

PROPP, EXODUS 1–18 (AB)

LAWS OF HAMMURABI (ROTH)

TKC: DOM

EXOD 1 .8–22

EXOD 2 .1–10

EXOD 2 .16–22

EXOD 4 .24–26

EXOD 6 .20

MEYERS, EXODUS (NCBC)

TKC: MIRIAM

SIX WOMEN, THEN MOSES

Before the deliverer says a word, six women have already defeated the policy. Two midwives refuse an execution order and lie to the king about it; a mother hides a child; a sister supervises the rescue; a princess of the ruling house adopts him and pays his mother to nurse him. The book's first act of resistance is professional non-compliance by women whose names the text keeps while it withholds Pharaoh's. **[C]**

WHO	WHAT THE TEXT ACTUALLY SAYS
Shiphrah and Puah	Midwives ordered to kill Hebrew boys at birth. They do not, they are summoned to account for it, and they answer with a claim the king cannot check. The text says they feared God, and that God dealt well with them and gave them households. Named, and the only characters in the chapter who are. **[C]**
The mother	Hides the child three months, then builds a waterproofed basket and places him in the reeds — a considered plan, not an abandonment. Named later as Jochebed. **[C]**
The sister	Stationed at a distance to watch, and intervenes at the moment of discovery to propose a Hebrew wet-nurse. Named later as Miriam; whether chapter 2 intends the same person is a reading the text does not spell out. **[P]**
Pharaoh's daughter	Sees, names, and raises a child her father's decree condemns, and pays his birth mother wages to do it. A woman inside the ruling house breaking the ruling house's law without ever opposing it publicly. **[C]**
Zipporah	A Midianite priest's daughter who marries Moses in exile, and who later performs a circumcision at night in a scene that saves him and that nobody explains. The deliverer's family is foreign, and his wife acts as a ritual agent. **[C]**
The oppression itself	Forced construction labor, quota increase as crowd control, then a birth policy. Population is the stated fear: the text says the king's worry is that they are numerous. Registration logic before any register exists. **[C]**

THE READING THE PULPIT SKIPS

Two of these women are professionals who lie to the state, and the text records approval. Two are mothers running an operation across a class line. One is a daughter of the regime. Any account of Exodus that begins with a burning bush has skipped the part where ordinary women had already made the deliverer possible. **[P]**

WHO IN MY CAST IS SHIPHRAH — INSIDE THE SYSTEM, QUIETLY NOT COMPLYING

BUILD THE REFUSAL

WRITING

EXOD 1

TKC: DOM · CT

Exodus 1 gives you a working model of resistance that does not look like resistance: people with licensed access refusing to do the one thing the license exists for. Draft Dominion's version here. This page is source material for the Trials, not an exercise.

1 · WHICH LICENSED PROFESSION IN DOMINION COULD REFUSE AN ORDER AND SURVIVE IT

2 · THE ANSWER THEY GIVE WHEN SUMMONED — WRITE IT AS DIALOGUE, NOT SUMMARY

3 · A WOMAN OF THE RULING HOUSE WHO BREAKS ITS LAW WITHOUT OPPOSING IT PUBLICLY

4 · THE POLICY THAT FOLLOWS WHEN QUIET REFUSAL IS DISCOVERED — WHAT ESCALATES

EXOD 3 .1–15

EXOD 4 .1–17

EXOD 6 .2–3

BDB · HALOT EHYEH

CHILDS, EXODUS (OTL)

PROPP, EXODUS 1–18

A NAME THAT WILL NOT SETTLE

Moses asks for a name to carry back as credentials, and receives a first-person verbal phrase, then a four-letter name, then a promise about ancestors. The transaction is credentialing: the whole scene turns on what authority a sent person can produce. **[C]**

THE SCENE	A bush that burns without being consumed, on a mountain, while Moses is working someone else's flock in a foreign country. The call reaches him at work, in exile, doing a job that belongs to his wife's family. **[C]**
WHAT GOD SAYS FIRST	Not a doctrine. A report of having heard: the cry, the taskmasters, the pain. The stated reason for acting is the noise the oppressed make. **[C]**
THE PHRASE IN 3:14	A first-person form of the Hebrew verb "to be," repeated with a relative particle. English renderings range from "I am who I am" through "I will be what I will be" to "I am the one who is." The grammar allows a future sense, so the tense you choose changes the theology. Check a lexicon before quoting it. **[R]**
THE FOUR LETTERS	The name given in 3:15 is the four-consonant name printed in most English Bibles as LORD in capitals. Jewish practice does not pronounce it; the vocalization now common in some Christian usage is a later reconstruction and is disputed. This companion prints the convention and does not print a pronunciation. **[R]**
FIVE OBJECTIONS	Moses refuses five times: who am I, what is your name, they will not believe me, I am not a speaker, send someone else. He is given signs, a name, and a brother to speak for him. The reluctance is not edited out, and the last refusal makes God angry. **[C]**
THE NIGHT SCENE	On the road back, a short and difficult passage has God seeking to kill Moses, and Zipporah circumcising their son and touching him with the foreskin, saying a phrase about a bridegroom of blood. Ancient and modern interpreters disagree about nearly every element. Do not smooth it. **[R]**

WHY A NAME IS THE THING HE ASKS FOR

In a world of named local gods, a name is jurisdiction: it tells you whose authority you are invoking and where it applies. Moses is not asking for metaphysics; he is asking what to say when the elders ask who sent him. Dominion understands this perfectly, which is why the Sanctum controls the forms of address. **[P]**

WHAT NAME I WAS TAUGHT FOR GOD, AND WHO TAUGHT ME NOT TO USE ANOTHER